HT BENGALURU

Wednesday, October 28, 2026

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L&T orders signal smooth sailing amid turbulence ▶P1

Flurry of caveats filed in TVS Group family feud ▶P1

Jio

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Highest number and value of applications in every investor category in India.

1.40 Cr
Applications

₹30,188 Cr
Issue size

79.62 Lakh
Shareholders

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Today, we take a historic step forward.
At its heart is the trust of a nation.
A Jio that you have helped build.

Jio's journey has always been about more than a company.
It is about the possibilities of a connected India,
and the exciting future that lies ahead.

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to all that we will make possible together as a nation.

So that more dreams find their chance.
And a billion ambitions take India forward.

With love, from Jio.
Anant, Isha and Akash Ambani

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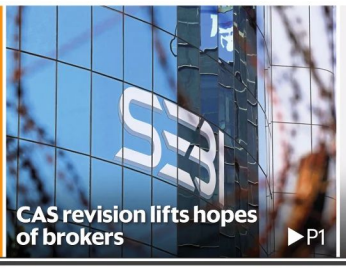
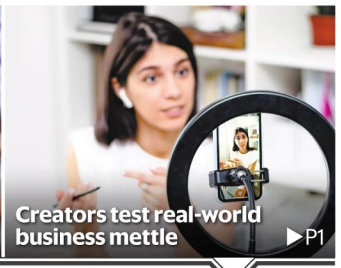


CAS revision lifts hopes of brokers ▶P1



Creators test real-world business mettle ▶P1

PROTEIN SHOULD NOT BE A LUXURY

It should be on every Indian plate

AVERAGE HEIGHT
(19 year boys, 2019)

INDIA	CHINA
5'5"	5'9"

OLYMPIC MEDALS
(Paris 2024)

INDIA	CHINA
6	91

PROTEIN AVAILABLE
(per person per day, FAO 2023)

INDIA	CHINA
75g	131g

2 Whey Scoops
46g protein
₹200*

VS.

3 MillD Rotis
46g protein
₹20*

* Prices are approximate

MillD.com
High Protein Atta

Savings Account | Fixed Deposit | Current Account | Premium Banking | Corporate Salary Account | NRI Banking
Investment & Wealth Solutions | Credit Card | Home Loan | Business Loan | Gold Loan | Overdraft | Working Capital Loan
Export/Import Finance | Vehicle Loan | Personal Loan | Trade, Forex and Remittances | Insurance

3,100+ Touchpoints | **21 States & 4 UTs** | **1.28 Cr.+ Customers** | **61,000 Employees**

*On account balances from ₹100 Crores to less than ₹750 Crores.
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HT BENGALURU VOL.1 NO.76

Wednesday, October 28, 2026

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Think Ahead. Think Growth.

mint primer

What's next for Tata Motors as Iveco deal passes

BY AYAAN KARTIK

After a 15-month process marked by regulatory delays and resistance from some shareholders, Tata Motors has secured 89.42% of Iveco Group shares, taking control of the Italian commercial vehicle (CV) maker. *Mint* explores the challenges & opportunities for Tata Motors.

BLOOMBERG

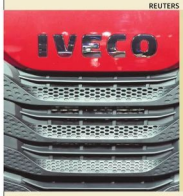
1 What will be Tata's next step?

The immediate next step is settlement. Tata Motors is scheduled to pay shareholders who tendered their shares on 30 October, four trading days after the tender offer closes. The company has said the offer will be followed by a 5-day reopening period from 2-6 November for shareholders who did not tender their shares, subject to conditions. The 87.8% acceptance gives Tata Motors the control needed to pursue its planned post-offer restructuring and eventual delisting of Iveco. The company had originally said that reaching at least 80% would allow it to proceed with the agreed share sale and take full ownership.

2 How will the Iveco integration work?

Cost savings are likely to be an early focus. Tata Motors has identified opportunities to use its engineering capabilities and common platforms to reduce product development costs, while increasing sourcing from Eastern Europe and Asia for Iveco. A crucial part to note is that Iveco recorded a 7% decline in revenue in 2025 to €13.4 billion, while profit more than halved to €233 million from €489 million a year earlier. Tata Motors earlier told analysts that the combination could generate synergies greater than those achieved through the acquisition of British luxury auto brand Jaguar Land Rover (JLR).

REUTERS



3 What changes will Tata make to Iveco's board?

Tata Sons chair N. Chandrasekaran, Tata Motors CV managing director Girish Wagh and Jaguar Land Rover chief executive PB Balaji are among the Tata executives designated to join Iveco's board. Tata Motors has also committed to a set of non-financial covenants covering Iveco's staff, organisation, governance and strategy for 2 years after settlement.

4 What does Tata gain from Iveco?

The biggest gain is global scale. The combined business will sell more than 540,000 vehicles a year and generate over $25 billion in revenue, per Tata's disclosures. Iveco gives Tata Motors a strong position in Europe and the No. 3 standing in Latin America, while Tata brings stronger positions in India and parts of Africa. The combination may also improve distribution in West Asia. Iveco also fills gaps in Tata Motors' product portfolio. It gives access to heavy-duty deep-mining trucks and tractor-trailers. among others.

5 Why does the deal matter for Tata?

The combination will make Tata Motors the world's 4th largest commercial vehicle (CV) firm. Iveco is central to Tata Group's ambition to build a much larger global automotive business. Tata Sons chair has set a target of about $100 billion in automotive revenue by FY31, with the CV business likely to bring roughly $40 billion. The target spans JLR, Tata Motors' passenger vehicle and commercial vehicle businesses, and Tata AutoComp. The acquisition gives Tata Motors' CV business a stronger global presence.

QUICK EDIT

When fear sells

One of the world's most talked-about companies has filed its public prospectus for an initial public offer, and it does not lack in grand claims. In its S-1 filing with the US Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC), Anthropic said that prospective owners of its stock should not think of picking up a stake in 'purely transactional terms.' Instead, they would be participants in a 'seminal' moment in human history, and be part of the firm's attempt to usher 'an age of miracles.'

But if AI is *perceived* to pose existential threats to humanity, if Anthropic's products are *perceived* to take away millions of jobs, Anthropic and its miracle-chasing investors may suffer from regulatory backlash, the prospectus warns. The prospectus makes no effort to dismiss such perceptions.

Such perceptions add to Anthropic's bottom-line. If more and more people believe they would become jobless without mastering Claude, Anthropic's subscription numbers would rise. If regulators believe they can't save the world without AI expertise, they would seek out Anthropic's experts in designing regulations. Greater the fear, higher the firm's value.

QUOTE OF THE DAY

We are looking to open markets in different countries... And I do hope that in the years to come, we will see India becoming a major exporter of goods and services to China and the ASEAN region also.

PIYUSH GOYAL
COMMERCE AND INDUSTRY MINISTER

He was speaking to reporters in the Hague

INSIDE

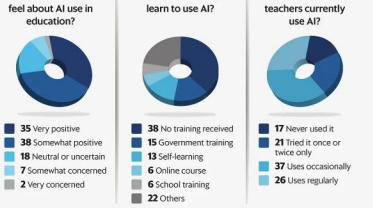
Mark to Market | Ather's run needs a supply boost >P4
Global | Anthropic sets up defining moment for Wall Street >P8
Money | Reels, drones and wedding Fomo: the price tag on 'I do' >P11
Views | Indian cities desperately need more public spaces >P12
Views | We need a holistic approach to tackle the urban heat problem >P13

mint | DATA BITES

HOW DO TEACHERS FEEL ABOUT AI IN SCHOOLS?

As NCERT introduces an AI module for Classes 9 to 12, a survey of teachers shows that despite feeling positive about AI's impact, only some use it regularly and many have no training.

Share of teachers (in %) by responses to the following questions



Survey of 797 government school teachers in Uttar Pradesh, Karnataka, Jharkhand and Maharashtra.

Data: Anjishnu Das
Graphic: Manu Choudhary
Source: Jan AI

COLUMNS

SOUMYA SARKAR
INDIA'S STEEL AMBITIONS REQUIRE A CLEAR CLIMATE TRANSITION ROADMAP >P12

Rahul Matthan
HUMAN VS AI WRITING: DOES IT TRULY MATTER WHO WRITES? >P12

Chandrakant Lahariya
DIAGNOSTIC FIRMS ARE USING AN OLD MARKETING PLAYBOOK >P13

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PLAIN FACTS

INDIA LOSES TOP SPOT TO VIETNAM IN SEP

BY PAYAL BHATTACHARYA | payal.bhattacharya@livemint.com

While robust gross domestic product (GDP) growth and solid domestic manufacturing keep India's fundamental macro engine strong, persistent foreign capital outflows and currency and stock market weaknesses reveal growing exposure to global headwinds.

EMERGING MARKETS TRACKER

Launched in September 2019, Mint's Emerging Markets Tracker provides a summary of economic activity across 12 large emerging markets based on seven high-frequency indicators. Vietnam moved up one place to take the top rank in the tracker, pushing India down to second place in September. China secured the third position.

Better performance

Country	Composite index score, latest	Real GDP growth (y-o-y, in %)	PMI manufacturing	Export growth (y-o-y, in %)	CPI inflation (y-o-y, in %)	Import cover (no. of months)	Exchange rate movement* (m-o-m, in %)	Stock market capitalization* (m-o-m, in %)
VIETNAM	71.8	10.0	51.9	39.5	5.1	1.9	0.6	2.7
INDIA	65.1	7.8	55.1	23.0	5.5	10.6	0.0	-2.2
CHINA	63.5	4.5	50.1	36.2	0.9	12.6	0.4	-0.6
MALAYSIA	60.3	5.3	49.9	54.7	1.8	3.6	-0.1	-2.2
INDONESIA	55.7	5.3	52.4	6.6	3.3	6.3	0.4	0.6
BRAZIL	52.3	2.0	44.8	12.9	4.6	14.7	0.4	6.8
THAILAND	51.3	1.9	54.3	24.1	2.8	7.4	-0.6	-1.4
RUSSIA	47.3	1.3	49.8	27.8	6.4	18.4	-1.6	0.5
SOUTH AFRICA	44.5	0.9	50.7	26.2	4.5	6.0	-0.2	-1.8
MEXICO	44.4	2.2	50	40	3.5	3.8	-1.2	-2.3
PHILIPPINES	28.0	2.3	49.6	27.9	7.2	7.8	-1.9	-4.9
TURKEY	8.8	2.3	47.9	8.1	29.7	2	-1.6	-9.1

Scoring method: The best-performing economy's value on any given indicator gets a score of 100, the worst one gets zero, and the rest are interpolated linearly for their relative scores. Scores for inflation for each country have been assigned based on the magnitude of deviation from the respective central bank target (mid-point in case of ranges). A country's composite index score is the simple average of its seven indicator scores. Latest available data used (as of 27 October 2026). Scores/ranks may change as more data comes in. *Change in monthly average. Exchange rate is against US dollar.

Source: Bloomberg, Mint calculations

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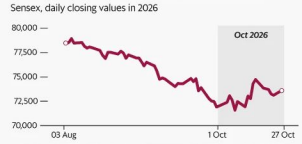
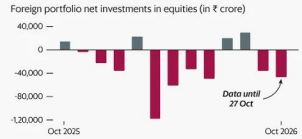
Sensex shows some recovery, but foreign selling pressures increased in October

Sensex, daily closing values in 2026



Foreign portfolio net investments in equities (in ₹ crore)



Source: BSE, National Securities Depository Ltd

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PRATEEK KUMAR/MINT

For the first time in five months, India lost its lead among emerging-market (EM) peers to Vietnam in September as poor stock performance proved to be a drag and strong export growth was barely enough.

According to the latest *Mint*'s Emerging Markets Tracker, which tracks the performance of 12 EMs on seven high-frequency indicators, India lagged Vietnam on five of them—GDP growth, inflation, currency movement, stock market capitalization, and export growth. The gap with Vietnam in the latter two was significant enough to pull India's ranking lower.

India's stock market capitalization declined 2.2% month-on-month in September, underscoring the paradox that has defined India's growth story in recent months—resilient economy alongside sluggish stock market and external vulnerabilities. Vietnam, on the other hand, posted a 2.7% rise.

When it comes to export growth, India's 23.0% figure looked strong in isolation, but completely paled in comparison to 39.5% recorded by Vietnam. In fact, China (3rd), Malaysia (4th), and Thailand (7th) recorded stronger export growth than India in the range of 24.1% to 54.7% in September. For other economies, the latest available comparable figures were for August.

While India remained the fastest-growing major economy, with 7.8% growth in April-June, Vietnam has clocked better growth with 8.8% in the same quarter. The latest growth data for July-September was even better at 10%, buoyed by booming exports and surging foreign investments.

Worsening inflation—1.5 percentage points higher than the Reserve Bank of India's medium-term aim of 4.0%—also dampened India's position. The rupee, on average, remained stable in September compared to August; four other EM currencies, including Vietnamese Dong, appreciated 0.4% to 0.6%.

All these factors were more than enough to offset India's better position in manufacturing purchasing managers' index (55.1 compared to 51.9 for Vietnam) and structural edge in import cover (10.6 months as against only 1.9 months for Vietnam).

FINANCIAL FRAGILITY

India continues to feel the fragility on the currency and stock market fronts. To begin with, foreign investors fled the Indian equity market more aggressively, withdrawing ₹46,748 crore between 1 October and 27 October—the highest since June. Despite this, the benchmark reflected some rebound in October, rising from 72,480.29 on 30 September to 73,598.67 on 27 October. However, the levels were still sharply lower than in early September.

When it comes to currency movement, the rupee has strengthened from 95.99 per dollar at the end of September to 95.19 on 27 October. This, however, has not come from natural strength, but a series of targeted measures announced in early October to reduce open-market dollar demand and curb speculative pressures.

While the rupee has strengthened, the Reserve Bank of India' (RBI) foreign exchange reserves are expected to take a further hit on top of the $64.69 billion decline in the six weeks following the record-high level of $785.70 billion on 4 September.

"Financial market conditions remained mixed heading into Q3. Following a 5.8% pull-back in the BSE Sensex in September amid global uncertainty, market sentiment stabilized with a 1.9% rebound in October," Icra said in its business activity monitor report for the month of September. While systemic liquidity tightened slightly, domestic capital market volatility as measured by the India VIX eased. Nevertheless, elevated input costs triggered by the West Asia war remain a critical monitorable for corporate profitability and market valuations, the report added.

INFLATIONARY PRESSURES

With price pressures continuing from the West Asia war—India's crude oil basket has averaged $120.3 per barrel in October so far as against $116.1 in September—India's inflation situation is expected to worsen. Along with food price rises and passthrough of input cost pressures, the base effect could push inflation up to 6% in October, resulting in at least two more interest rate hikes by RBI. As US bond yields remain elevated and the US Federal Reserve is expected to raise interest rates further, it creates a high bar for EMs, including India, in attracting foreign flows.

GROWTH MODERATION

Against the backdrop of rising inflation and interest rate, India's growth is expected to slow down to 7% in the second quarter of the current fiscal year, according to Icra. The recent flare-up in prices is expected to weigh on business margins and value-added growth in the industrial sector, while deficient monsoon will pull agriculture growth down. A higher interest rate environment could also dampen India's credit growth, which played a key role in supporting growth in earlier quarters.

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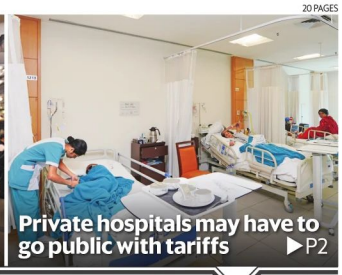
Anthropic IPO sets defining moment for Wall Street ▶P8



Private hospitals may have to go public with tariffs ▶P2

L&T Q2 signals smooth sailing amid upheavals

Record order books in Sep quarter highlights limited impact from war

Nehal Chaliawala
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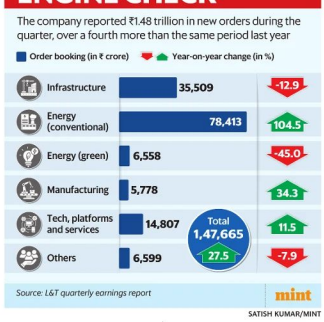
MUMBAI

ENGINE CHECK

The company reported ₹1.48 trillion in new orders during the quarter, over a fourth more than the same period last year



SATISH KUMAR/MINT

Infrastructure giant Larsen & Toubro Ltd (L&T) shrugged off geopolitical headwinds to report record order flows in the September quarter, calming concerns over shocks from the West Asia conflict.

Escalations such as the Houthi militia attacks in West Asia, L&T's most important geography outside India, have not had a significant effect on project execution, said Subramanian Sarma, L&T's deputy managing director & president.

Employees were safe and work continued at its project sites, he said at a post-earnings media call on Tuesday.

However, L&T was not unscathed by the war either—delays in material shipments to the region lengthened project execution timelines and costs for India's largest infrastructure player.

This reflected as margin erosion during the July-September quarter.

"Business tendering activity is pretty much on the normal course; may be some delay of a couple of weeks in terms of decision-making, but otherwise, we're still seeing a reasonably good pipeline of business," Sarma said about the situation in West Asia.

L&T is often considered a bellwether for the state of the Indian economy, given its large revenue share from India's public and private infrastructure expenditure.

"The multiple disruptions, both local and overseas, have created some execution headwinds during the quarter. We've also been faced with escalations in input costs and delays and spike in logistics costs, etc., which have had an effect on margins," said R. Shankar Raman, L&T's president & whole-time director, finance, said during a post-earnings media call on Tuesday.

The Mumbai-based company reported ₹1.48 trillion in new orders during the quarter, over a fourth more than the same period last year, taking its consolidated orderbook to a record ₹8.5 trillion.

This included high contributions from its onshore and offshore hydrocarbon businesses, public spaces and airports, power transmission and distribution, and its Carbon-Lite Solutions unit. Nearly two-thirds of the business came from overseas.

TURN TO PAGE 6

DON'T MISS

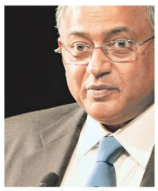
Maruti's Q2 profit falls 26%
Maruti Suzuki has warned that weak monsoon rains could weigh on rural demand. It reported a 26% on-year drop in net profit to ₹2,466 crore in Q2 FY27. >P5

'Advantage for India in US deal'
Union minister Piyush Goyal said that under the trade deal with the US, India will get a comparative advantage over other nations and preferential access to the US market. >P2

JLR bets on local assembly, EVs
Jaguar Land Rover is stepping up localization and preparing to introduce four EVs in India over the next year, seeking to strengthen its position in the nation's luxury car market. >P6

Flurry of caveats filed in TVS feud

Varun Sood & Satish John
BENGALURU/MUMBAI



Venu Srinivasan, TVS Motor's chairman-emeritus. BLOOMBERG

The feuding family members of the TVS Group have filed a slew of caveats in Chennai courts, as an ownership dispute hangs over the Chennai-based business conglomerate. TVS Motor Co. chairman-emeritus Venu Srinivasan, son Sudarshan Venu, wife Mallika Srinivasan, and daughter Lakshmi Venu have filed a total of eight caveats in two Chennai courts, a *Mint* review of court records showed.

On 12 October, Venu Srinivasan filed the first, naming Lakshmi and Mallika Srinivasan in the City Civil Court. The same day, Mallika Srinivasan filed a caveat, naming Venu and Sudarshan. All four family members also filed caveats in the Commercial Court the same day. Lakshmi Venu also filed a caveat in the City Civil Court the next day, naming her father, while Sudarshan filed a case against

TURN TO PAGE 10

CAS revision lifts hopes of brokers

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MUMBAI

On 15 October, Sebi revised the CAS framework. REUTERS

The Securities and Exchange Board of India's (Sebi's) decision to revise its closing auction session (CAS) framework has raised hopes of a recovery in derivatives trading and brokerage revenues, offering relief to brokers hit by a sharp slowdown in key income streams.

Sebi revised the CAS framework on 15 October, restoring the 30-minute VWAP for settling derivatives contracts on expiry days. The changes will take effect on 7 December. The regulator's move followed concerns that the framework, introduced on 3 August, had caused abrupt price swings and uncertainty over settlement values on expiry days, prompting market participants to flag risks to liquidity and price discovery.

The framework determines closing prices for 213 stocks traded in the futures and

TURN TO PAGE 6

Creators test real-world business mettle

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MUMBAI

Content creators are moving beyond paid brand partnerships to launch their own consumer businesses. ISTOCKPHOTO

A growing number of content creators are moving beyond paid brand partnerships to launch their own consumer businesses, to capitalize on their relationships with followers to find initial customers and test demand.

The trend comes as India's creator economy expands, even as some celebrity-backed consumer brands struggle to sustain growth. For smaller creators, an engaged niche audience can provide an initial customer base, but industry experts say long-term success depends on product quality, customer retention and the ability to attract buyers beyond their followers.

Lifestyle creators Shivani Manchekar and Yash Mathadhikari launched their saree brand Padmora on 11 October with about ₹15 lakh of personal savings. The initial stock sold out within three days, and the brand has had 180 buyers since, the founders said.

Other examples include perfume brand Sarkar, launched by actor and content creator Bhuvan Bam in July 2026, and Underneat, an innerwear and shapewear brand launched by actor, comedian and content creator Kusha Kapila in April 2025. Neither brand responded to *Mint*'s queries.

Amrita Paul, a mechanical engineer and beauty, fashion and lifestyle creator, founded FurnNsteel, a steel furniture manufacturing business, in 2019. The company primarily sells to wholesalers, dealers and distributors, as well as individual consumers. FurnNsteel's revenue grew 12% year-on-year in FY26, while its net profit has grown by 8-10% annually, according to Paul.

"Having worked as a content creator with several consumer brands, I had observed a gap between online and offline marketing. When I started FurnNsteel, I made sure to build brand awareness across multiple platforms to maximise visibility, alongside offline campaigns," Paul said.

Paul's venture illustrates how a creator's business need not fall within their content niche. "A creator's individual voice and perspective play a big role in why they want to build something of their own. They have spent years understanding their audience, what

TURN TO PAGE 10

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MINT SHORTS

Telcos push DoT for high-power use of 6GHz Wi-Fi band

New Delhi: Telecom operators Reliance Jio, Bharti Airtel and Vodafone Idea have urged the Department of Telecommunications (DoT) to allow high-power outdoor use of the lower end of the 6GHz Wi-Fi band, saying that it could help expand high-speed broadband access in areas where fibre deployment is difficult or expensive. The request was made through the Cellular Operators Association of India (COAI). **JATIN GROVER**

Gadkari warns of penalties for poor highway quality

PTI

New Delhi: The Centre will use Network Surveillance Vehicles to identify potholes across national highways and hold contractors, consultants and officials accountable for poor road quality, road transport and highways minister Nitin Gadkari said on Tuesday. Those found compromising on quality would face penalties and blacklisting, he said at a CII conference in New Delhi. **SUBHASH NARAYAN**

GST officers must establish intent to evade tax before applying law

New Delhi: GST field officers will now have to prove the intent of a taxpayer to evade taxes before invoking the stringent GST law provision relating to "fraud, wilful-misstatement, or suppression of facts" for raising tax demand, the Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs has stated in a circular. These provisions would also not be applied in scrutiny cases solely because a discrepancy has been noticed, it said. **PTI**

'No intention to raise ethanol blending in fuel beyond 20%'

BLOOMBERG

Panaji: Union minister of petroleum and natural gas Hardeep Singh Puri on Tuesday said the Centre has no immediate plan to increase the ethanol blending in petrol beyond the current 20%. Misinformation about E20 (20% ethanol-blended petrol) was a "contrived narrative," he said during an interaction at the inauguration of the 29th Energy Technology and Innovation Meet in South Goa. **PTI**

MoRTH notifies FASTag-based annual local pass

New Delhi: The Centre has introduced an annual toll pass for eligible residents living within 20km of national highway toll plazas, offering unlimited crossings at a designated plaza for up to ₹3,000 a year. The move addresses a longstanding limitation of the existing monthly pass and comes as the rollout of barrier-less tolling makes informal arrangements for local commuters harder to sustain. **SUBHASH NARAYAN**

GST rules on post-sale discounts, export refunds change from 1 Nov

New Delhi: Changes to India's goods and services tax (GST) rules governing post-sale discounts, export refunds and tax procedures will take effect on 1 November, easing documentation businesses need and clarifying eligibility for certain exporter refunds. The finance ministry notified the implementation date on 26 October, bringing Sections 153 to 155 of the Finance Act, 2026, into force. The provisions amend Sections 15, 34 and 54 of the Central Goods and Services Tax Act, 2017. **DHIRENDRA KUMAR**

'India to get comparative advantage in US trade deal'

Minister Piyush Goyal says the proposed agreement will give India preferential access

Utpal Bhaskar
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THE HAGUE

India's commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal said that under the proposed trade agreement with the US, India will get a comparative advantage over other countries and preferential access to the US market.

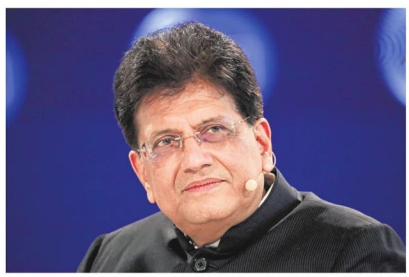
The development assumes significance amid growing uncertainty in global trade following the ongoing wars in West Asia and Ukraine.

Goyal said in a late Monday night (India time) press briefing, "And in the US also, we will get a comparative advantage from other countries. We will get preferential access. So, now the story has started." He had earlier on Monday said India and the US had concluded most of the discussions and were fine-tuning the proposed trade agreement.

Efforts towards a limited India-US trade deal first began in 2018, during President Donald Trump's first term, but were put on hold under the Biden administration.

Talks were revived last year after Trump returned to office.

Goyal added that concluded trade agreements and those under negotiation would give India preferential access to $85 trillion of the $115 trillion global GDP. In response to a *Mint* query, Goyal said the proposed free trade agreement (FTA) with Chile was at an advanced stage of conclusion, while Mexico was keen to secure an early harvest deal.



Commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal. BLOOMBERG

2018
The year efforts for a limited India-US trade deal started

He added that good progress was being made on the proposed Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) with Canada.

Discussions with Mercosur (Mercado Común del Sur, or Southern Common Market) could also be accelerated now that elections in Brazil were over.

Goyal said countries including Ecuador and several in Africa wanted to sign FTAs with India. India has eight trade negotiations underway. "Egypt has invited us to discuss potentially how we can work more," Goyal said, adding, "We have just started SACU (Southern African Customs Union) negotiations. So, it may take some time." He said negotiations with the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC), which would add the four other Gulf countries and Israel, could take longer because of the West Asia crisis. "The GCC, which would add those four other countries of the Gulf and Israel. These negotiations for obvious reasons because of the West Asia crisis may take some time. Though we are ready to speed up negotiations.

$85 tn
Preferential access for India expected from agreement

These proposed trade deals come in the backdrop of global supply chains getting affected and a global slowdown.

"The Eurasia FTA is only about goods. It doesn't include services. Hence, we are still assessing the benefits of entering into that agreement," Goyal said, adding that while many other countries were talking to India and wanted an FTA, "But we also don't have more bandwidth at the moment."

In response to a *Mint* query about building institutional capacity and sectoral expertise for trade negotiations, Goyal said the government had been working to ensure that experience gained in negotiations was retained and used in future agreements.

"Prime Minister Narendra Modi has been very focused on this aspect. That our negotiations and all the learnings and effort that's going in should not become a one-time affair. And therefore, in the last three years or so, we've prepared proper manuals which are a guide like a standard operating practice, SOP, towards proper and organized FTA negotiations.

Every FTA that we enter into, we prepare a lot of documentation for future reference and to help guide officers in the future because people keep changing. And lastly, I think Indians are basically smarter."

The writer is in The Hague as the guest of the Confederation of Indian Industry

Ramita Mishra contributed to the story

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

SC seeks govt reply to plea over data law

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NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Tuesday sought the government's response to a plea by news publishers challenging provisions of India's data protection law, which they say could restrict investigative journalism, expose confidential sources and force reporters to seek consent from people they investigate.

The Digital News Publishers Association (DNPA), which represents news organisations, has challenged provisions of the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act, 2023, arguing that it lacks an adequate exemption for journalism. Provisions allowing people to seek deletion of their personal data could also affect published reports and digital archives, it adds, while the government's powers to demand information could expose confidential sources.

"We have raised the argument concerning exemptions as well. Otherwise, newsrooms will shut down if we have to ask for permission," senior counsel Madhavi Goradia Divan told the three-judge bench, led by Chief Justice of India. "We have to ask your permission if we report on you. How can that ever be? What is news otherwise?"

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Private hospitals may have to go public with tariffs on services

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NEW DELHI

Private hospitals in India will soon be required to upload their tariff structures and other details to a central government portal, allowing patients to compare costs and make informed treatment decisions, according to two officials familiar with the plan.

Hospitals will have to upload their charges, available specialities, registration details and grievance officer contacts to the government portal under the Clinical Establishments Act (CEA), as part of a plan to improve transparency in hospital billing and grievance redressal.

The Centre, however, has no immediate plan to enforce uniform price ceilings or to step into tariff regulation, according to the officials.

Mint reported on 12 October that Union health secretary Punya Salila Srivastava had directed states and Union territories to ensure healthcare service rates were prominently displayed at hospital reception desks. The proposed central portal marks the next step, requiring private hospitals to upload their complete tariff cards online so patients can access pricing information before visiting a facility.

The Centre, however, has no immediate plan to enforce uniform price ceilings. MINT

Information asymmetry can lead to opaque billing, inflated prices for consumables and arbitrary charges during medical emergencies, potentially pushing households into debt. The risk is significant in India, where the private sector accounts for nearly 70% of outpatient care and 60% of inpatient care. Income disparities across states further compound the problem.

Government replies in Parliament, including figures from the Union health ministry, put the number of private hospitals in India at 43,486–44,100. In 2022-23, Indian households spent ₹3.83 trillion on healthcare out of pocket, accounting for 43.4% of total health expenditure, showed health ministry's National Health Accounts.

"The platform will force complete transparency on what hospitals are charging patients for various procedures and clinical services. But right now, we are saying hospitals should transparently display their charges," said one of the two officials on condition of anonymity.

The platform will serve as a public directory where healthcare establishments must submit accurate administrative and pricing data for access by both the government and the public, the official added.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

NPPA slashes cancer drug MRPs by up to 93%

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NEW DELHI

Cancer medicines in India are about to carry much lower price tags. The government's drug price regulator has cut retail prices by up to 93.3%, with the new rates taking effect on 9 November, according to two officials and a government document reviewed by *Mint*.

The National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA) has reset the maximum retail price (MRP), the most a shop can charge, on 543 versions of 137 cancer drugs that have no government-fixed price ceiling. The biggest drop in rupees is on thiotepa, a chemotherapy injection used before stem cell transplants and to treat bladder cancer. A 100mg vial of Samtepa goes from ₹80,071.86 to ₹7,150.33, a cut of ₹72,921.53, or 91.1%. In percentage terms, the sharpest fall is on palbociclib, a breast cancer drug.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

SC flays govt over medicine markups

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NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Tuesday criticized the Centre for failing to adequately justify steep markups on medicines, asking why it took years to cap trade margins on selected anti-cancer drugs and whether commercial considerations were being prioritised over patients' lives.

A bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta reserved its order in a public interest litigation (PIL) filed in 2023 by advocate and activist Kishan Chand Jain, seeking affordable medicines and reforms in drug pricing and medical regulation.

The court questioned hospitals' pricing practices, asking why medicines were sold to patients at maximum retail prices (MRPs) that were far above their procurement costs.

"The lives of people, Ms Bhati...don't take it as commerce. Treat it as the life of the poorest citizen of this country," the bench told additional solicitor general Aishwarya Bhati, appearing for the Centre. "We have asked you no less than 30 times to tell us this justification," it added.

The Supreme Court reserved its order on the PIL. PTI

The hearing took place after the government capped trade margins at 30% of MRP for selected non-scheduled anti-cancer medicines through a notification issued on 17 October.

According to the Centre's submission, the measure is expected to reduce retail prices by 20–70%.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Support prices, demand for edible oil to drive mustard area expansion

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NEW DELHI

Farmers are likely to plant more mustard this winter, helped by a higher government support price and a need to buy less cooking oil from abroad.

The mustard area under cultivation in the ongoing 2026-27 rabi season is projected to touch 9.50 million hectares (mn ha.), against 9.42mn ha. a year before, said Vijay Veer Singh, director at the ICAR-Indian Institute of Rapeseed-Mustard Research in Bharatpur, Rajasthan, the country's biggest mustard-producing state. Better seeds and hybrid varieties should help farmers grow more on each hectare.

The timing is important as India buys about 60% of its edible oil from other countries, and the war in West Asia has made those imports costlier and harder to ship.

Even if yields stay where they were, the extra area could take mustard output to 13.9 million tonnes (mt) this season, up from 13.77mt last year, assuming productivity remains at 1,460kg per hectare. Meanwhile, edible oil demand is projected to rise to 26.5mt in FY27 from 25.7mt a year before, *Mint* reported on 22 October.

The mustard area under cultivation in the ongoing 2026-27 rabi season is projected to touch 9.50 million hectares. AFP

However, experts advise constant monitoring of the crop situation. According to Singh, moisture availability is likely to be a major constraint on mustard acreage in 2026-27, while favourable prices and the crop's relatively lower irrigation requirement compared with wheat could support planting.

Rajasthan, UP, MP, West Bengal and Haryana are the top five major mustard-growing areas in India. Other states include Jharkhand, Assam, Gujarat, Bihar, Punjab, Chhattisgarh, Maharashtra, Uttarakhand, HP, and Andhra Pradesh. The Minimum Support Price (MSP) for rapeseed and mustard is ₹6,613 per quintal for the current rabi marketing season, approved by the Cabinet on 30 September 2026, reflecting an increase of ₹413 per quintal over the previous year, which experts feel will drive area under cultivation.

According to data from CCS Haryana Agricultural University, Hisar, the highest area of 9.42mn ha. was achieved in 2025-26, and the highest productivity of 1,524kg per hectare was achieved in the year 2020-21. Area under mustard has increased from 6.70mn ha. in 2020-21 to 9.42mn ha. in 2025-26. This represents an increase of 40.6% over five years.

"We are expecting mustard acreage to remain healthy this rabi season, supported by favourable prices and steady demand. If the weather conditions remain favourable, acreage could see a further increase over last year," said Namit Singla, a trader in Delhi.

"The mustard crop has become an attractive crop because of reasonably good yield, consistent increase in MSP and market price over and above MSP. Area has shifted to mustard from wheat and other location-specific rabi crops," said Baldev Raj Kamboj, vice chancellor, CCS Haryana Agricultural University, Hisar (Haryana).

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First published in February 2007 to serve as an unbiased and clear-minded chronicler of the Indian Dream.

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MINT SHORTS

Advent International raises $30 bn, beats flagship target

Mumbai: Global private equity firm Advent International has raised close to $27 billion for its 11th flagship fund (GPE XI)—surpassing its target of $26 billion—and more than $3 billion for its new mid-market strategy, the company said in a statement on Tuesday. As of June 2026, Advent oversees more than $109 billion in assets under management and has made 460 investments across 45 countries. It operates 18 offices across five continents and has expanded its footprint over the past two years by opening locations in Sydney—extending into Australia and New Zealand—and Tokyo, marking its entry into Japan. **PRIYAMVADA C**

Nvidia, Meta deepen AI ties with $3 billion investment deal

AFP

Nvidia and Meta said on Tuesday they would deepen their partnership on the Muse artificial intelligence (AI) assistant and related AI models, with Nvidia investing $3 billion in the Facebook parent's equity offering. Meta's Muse models and agents, which run on Nvidia infrastructure, will work more closely with the chipmaker to improve performance and reduce costs. The companies may also explore working together more on Nvidia's OpenShell framework. **REUTERS**

Cent raises $15 million to expand health screening business

Bengaluru: Preventive health screening startup Cent has raised $15 million in a Series A funding round comprising equity and debt, led by Blume Ventures and existing investor South Park Commons, the company announced on Tuesday. The Bengaluru-based Cent was founded by Khandelwal alongside Practo co-founder Shashank ND and Arpit Garg. **RWIT GHOSH**

DeepSeek AI model shows safety gaps in independent tests

Beijing: DeepSeek's latest AI (artificial intelligence) model showed stronger safety controls in independent tests than earlier versions, but could still disable software intended to shut it down, exploit gaps in monitoring and follow deceptive instructions during long tasks, according to a Chinese AI-safety group. DeepSeek is one of China's most closely-watched AI companies. **REUTERS**

Lunate bullish on India, wary of price

The Abu Dhabi firm holds a stake in NSE, which went public last month

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ABU DHABI

Abu Dhabi-based Lunate, which manages $125 billion in assets, views India as a standout emerging market, driven by a decade of resilient economic growth and deepening capital markets, a top executive at the investment firm told *Mint*.

"India offers strong growth tailwinds and a wide range of attractive investment opportunities. While global investors often focus on funding costs and interest rates, our higher-(interest rates)-for-longer outlook is primarily driven by strong economic growth," Lunate's head of investment research Caesar Maasry said in an interview.

"We believe the funding-related headwinds facing India are less severe than many investors fear, and we do not expect a repeat of the challenges seen in the 2010s or the 1990s," he added.

Caesar Maasry, head of investment research, Lunate.

Maasry is responsible for the firm's macroeconomic views and return forecasts across public and private markets. These forecasts drive the asset allocation process across Lunate's various investment strategies. Before joining Lunate, Maasry spent more than two decades at Goldman Sachs across New York, London, and Hong Kong.

With a core focus on private markets, Lunate works with a diverse client base that includes institutions, family offices and corporates and invests across multiple asset classes and geographies through co-mingled funds, customized portfolios and separately managed accounts (SMAs).

Lunate has also established Alterra, the world's largest private climate investment vehicle, and Axight, focused on mid-market opportunities in Asia Pacific. In addition to its private markets platform, Lunate also has a range of conventional and thematic exchange traded funds (ETFs), defined benefit solutions through Ghaf Benefits, and wealth management services. Within the Asia-Pacific region and broader emerging markets, India is an important area of investment, Maasry said. "While Indian equities look relatively expensive compared to global peers on a valuation-to-growth basis, other Asian markets have de-rated, with potential downside risks to their earnings estimates. Despite India's rich valuations, we continue to find compelling investment opportunities," he said.

He said while north Asia has benefited significantly from the AI and semiconductor boom, its growth has historically been more cyclical. "In private markets, where investments are less liquid and typically held for several years, entry valuations are critical. While India's asset valuations remain elevated, we believe its medium-term growth outlook is supported by strong tailwinds," Maasry said.

Lunate holds a stake in National Stock Exchange of India Ltd, which went public last month in the country's second-largest initial public offering. Other key transactions include a pre-IPO investment in ICICI Prudential AMC and a stake acquisition in Advanta Enterprises alongside Alpha Wave.

The reporter is in Abu Dhabi at the invitation of the government.

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INDIA BET

LUNATE has established Alterra, the world's largest private climate investment vehicle

WITH a core focus on private markets, Lunate works with a diverse client base

LUNATE has also established Axight for Asia-Pacific mid-market deals

Unicorn India Ventures' US push to aid growth, exits

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BENGALURU

Early-stage venture capital firm Unicorn India Ventures' (UIV) expansion to the US is meant to help its portfolio companies scale faster and access quicker exit opportunities, according to the firm's founder.

"We've done this for our portfolio companies, to provide them with propulsion for growth as well as connectivity with local businesses," Bhaskar Majumdar, founder and managing partner at Unicorn India Ventures, told *Mint* in an interview. "Hopefully, we'll see a shrinking in exit timelines because this also provides them with new potential acquirers or potential M&As (Mergers and Acquisitions)."

UIV isn't the only Indian VC firm to set up a base in the US, given fund managers' long history of spending time there. While these visits were once about bringing Silicon Valley's technology trends and insights back home, the push over the past 18 months has been driven by a desire not to miss out on the artificial intelligence boom playing out over 13,000 km away.

A third of UIV's ₹1,200-crore fund came from US-based investors. BLOOMBERG

Unlike other Indian funds expanding to the US, the firm remains focused on Indian founders

While funds such as Nexus Venture Partners have maintained a long-standing presence there, others such as Peak XV and Z47 opened new US offices in 2026. Blume Ventures co-founder Sanjay Nath is also based out of San Francisco. However, unlike most Indian funds that have set up shop in the US, the firm's thesis remains firmly rooted in backing local founders in India. The US office is not designed to serve as a growth amplifier for Indian portfolio companies, Majumdar said. "It helps us bring in relevant co-investors in later rounds. In the US, there are funds that specialise in certain sectors, which makes it easier for some of our portfolio companies to raise money as well," he added.

The firm's US operations will also be more targeted, with local partner and recent hire Kishore Kanakamedala tasked with helping portfolio companies expand into the region.

For UIV, the move to the US is a natural progression, given that a third of its ₹1,200-crore ($135 million in 2025) third fund came from US-based limited partners. The firm is deploying capital from its fourth fund, a ₹1,000-crore vehicle launched in partnership with IIT Madras and IIT Madras Research Park.

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Extract of Standalone Unaudited Financial Results for the quarter and half year ended September 30, 2026

INR in million, except per share data

Sr. No	Particulars	Quarter ended			Half year ended		Year ended
		September 30, 2026	June 30, 2026	September 30, 2025	September 30, 2026	September 30, 2025	March 31, 2026
		Unaudited	Unaudited	Unaudited	Unaudited	Unaudited	Audited
1	Total Income from Operations	533,402	524,557	423,323	1,057,959	809,253	1,832,661
2	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and / or Extraordinary Items)	31,658	43,413	42,909	75,071	91,969	188,629
3	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after Tax (after Exceptional and / or Extraordinary Items)	24,149	33,521	33,028	57,670	70,609	144,454
4	Total Comprehensive Income /(Loss) for the period [comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income /(Loss) (after tax)]	26,335	34,682	35,622	61,017	76,665	149,269
5	Equity Share Capital	1,572	1,572	1,572	1,572	1,572	1,572
6	Reserve as shown in the Audited Balance Sheet						1,049,526
7	Earnings Per Share (of INR 5 each) (for continuing and discontinued operations)						
	(a) Basic	76.81	106.62	105.05	183.43	224.58	459.46
	(b) Diluted	76.81	106.62	105.05	183.43	224.58	459.46

Extract of Consolidated Unaudited Financial Results for the quarter and half year ended September 30, 2026

INR in million, except per share data

Sr. No	Particulars	Quarter ended			Half year ended		Year ended
		September 30, 2026	June 30, 2026	September 30, 2025	September 30, 2026	September 30, 2025	March 31, 2026
		Unaudited	Unaudited	Unaudited	Unaudited	Unaudited	Audited
1	Total Income from Operations	533,555	524,698	423,442	1,058,253	809,494	1,833,160
2	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and / or Extraordinary Items)	32,191	44,412	43,393	76,603	92,828	191,185
3	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after Tax (after Exceptional and / or Extraordinary Items)	24,661	34,469	33,490	59,130	71,414	146,795
4	Total Comprehensive Income /(Loss) for the period [comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income / (Loss) (after tax)]	26,844	35,631	36,095	62,475	77,484	151,608
5	Equity Share Capital	1,572	1,572	1,572	1,572	1,572	1,572
6	Reserve as shown in the Audited Balance Sheet						1,069,991
7	Earnings Per Share (of INR 5 each) (for continuing and discontinued operations)						
	(a) Basic	78.44	109.63	106.52	188.07	227.14	466.90
	(b) Diluted	78.44	109.63	106.52	188.07	227.14	466.90

Note: The above is an extract of the detailed format of the Standalone and Consolidated Financial Results for the quarter and half year ended September 30, 2026 filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Standalone and Consolidated Financial Results for the quarter and half year ended September 30, 2026 are available on the websites of BSE and NSE at www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com and on Company's website at www.marutisuzuki.com.

For and on behalf of Board of Directors

Place : New Delhi
Date : October 27, 2026

(Hisashi Takeuchi)
Managing Director & CEO

Have fun with facts on Sundays

Catch the latest column of
HT TWTW
THE WEEK THAT WAS
A quiz on the week's development.

Sunday Hindustan Times
TWTW
Take a cue from the clues

HT /FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

BSE Sensex	Nifty 50	Nifty 500	Nifty Next 50	Nifty 100	BSE 150 MidCap	BSE 250 SmallCap
CLOSE 73,598.67	CLOSE 22,749.75	CLOSE 21,734.90	CLOSE 67,343.95	CLOSE 23,689.95	CLOSE 15,480.03	CLOSE 6,631.10
PERCENT CHANGE -0.01	PERCENT CHANGE -0.02	PERCENT CHANGE 0.58	PERCENT CHANGE 1.30	PERCENT CHANGE 0.22	PERCENT CHANGE 1.05	PERCENT CHANGE 2.00
PREVIOUS CLOSE 73,606.75	PREVIOUS CLOSE 22,753.20	PREVIOUS CLOSE 21,608.75	PREVIOUS CLOSE 66,477.15	PREVIOUS CLOSE 23,637.10	PREVIOUS CLOSE 15,319.25	PREVIOUS CLOSE 6,501.25
OPEN 73,484.38	OPEN 22,708.80	OPEN 21,597.40	OPEN 66,547.85	OPEN 23,603.90	OPEN 15,361.34	OPEN 6,507.03
HIGH 73,762.98	HIGH 22,829.75	HIGH 21,782.05	HIGH 67,359.45	HIGH 23,754.20	HIGH 15,512.58	HIGH 6,636.20
LOW 73,179.41	LOW 22,636.85	LOW 21,559.85	LOW 66,515.00	LOW 23,560.90	LOW 15,336.88	LOW 6,494.48

Ather's run needs a supply boost

Ananya Roy
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Ather Energy Ltd has finally eked out a quarterly net profit, sending its stock soaring as much as 21% in two days and closer to its all-time high of ₹1,744, hit on 1 September.

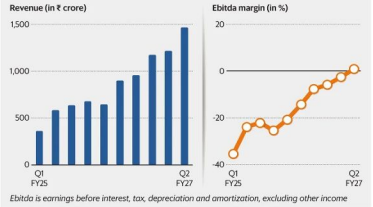
Operating revenue grew 63% year-on-year to ₹1,464 crore in the September quarter (Q2FY27), while net profit stood at ₹1.26 crore—the first positive quarterly bottom line reported by the electric two-wheeler maker.

Although commodity price pressures have sustained through FY27 so far, Ather turned Ebitda-profitable with a 0.8% margin versus a negative 2.7% in Q1. The Q2 Ebitda margin including other income stands at 5.1%, compared with 0.8% in Q1.

The turnaround has been led by operating leverage even as supply continued to cap growth. Against a 108% on-year growth in demand, as measured by pre-orders, registrations rose only 60% to 92,600 units. Production grew 45% to 98,400 units. The management acknowledged

Turning the corner

Ather Energy posted its first quarterly net profit in Q2FY27 as scale continued to drive up operating leverage.



Ebitda is earnings before interest, tax, depreciation and amortization, excluding other income

Source: Company

mint

MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

18,000-20,000 units per month of retail demand remains unrealized.

Towards this, capacity expansion is underway in full swing. The enhancement of its Hosur facility is expected to be completed in Q3, while Phase 1 of the AURIC plant in Maharashtra is slated for Q4. Together, they are expected to more than double capacity from 420,000 units to 920,000 units by FY27-end. The long-term capacity target stands at 1.64 million units.

Operating leverage should dial up with capacity expansion, while the management also pushes the pedal on dealer network expansion from Q4. But the impact on margins will be less straightforward. The AURIC ramp-up is expected to *add* to costs from Q4.

The management expects the net impact to be positive as the new launch Konarc offers structurally better unit economics than the Rizta model—6-7% higher gross margins over the long term.

It will have to be seen whether this sustains with entry variants (SR1) expected to be launched in Q4. The management has started with mid-variants (SR2 and SR3) keeping in mind production availability and margin considerations. Konarc's early traction in the North is encouraging and bodes well for expansion of its addressable market.

Better pricing and product mix have helped support margins over the first two quarters of FY27. Commodity inflation eroded 940 basis points (bps) from the gross margin. Structural improvements including price hikes and cost-reduction initiatives added 530 bps and growth in high-range models added another 270 bps to the gross margin. Effectively, the gross margin (including other income) came in at 24%, down 140 bps from Q4FY26 levels.

Its weighted average ex-showroom price rose to ₹1.64 lakh in Q2 from ₹1.50 lakh in Q4FY26, while AtherStack Pro's 94% attach rate helped sustain high-margin, non-vehicle revenue share at 15%. While copper prices have spiked on AI-related demand and plastic has turned expensive amid the West Asia war, the management expects commodities to remain broadly flat in Q3. Thus, no price hikes are planned in Q3.

NEXT HURDLE

PRODUCTION ramp-up must keep pace with demand to arrest the market-share slide to 15.1%

ATHER has said 18,000-20,000 units per month of retail demand remains unrelated

But production ramp-up and dealer availability must keep pace with demand to arrest the market-share slide from 17.2% to 15.1% over the past year. Competition and commodity price volatility remain risks. Nomura Research values Ather at 4x EV/sales on FY29 estimates, which it considers "very attractive" given its higher growth potential than peers.

IOB to sell shares in tranches to trim govt shareholding

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IOB plans to raise tech spend to over ₹1,800 crore in FY27, says CEO Ajay Srivastava.

Indian Overseas Bank (IOB) plans to start raising ₹5,000 crore in tranches towards the end of the December quarter or early next quarter, depending on market conditions, managing director and chief executive, Ajay Kumar Srivastava said. The state-run bank's board approved the proposal in July, he said.

The fundraise could reduce the government's holding by six percentage points from 92.44% as of September, Srivastava said. This would help the lender meet the requirement that at least 25% of a listed entity's shares be held by public shareholders.

While state-run banks with over 75% government holding received extensions to meet the minimum public float rule, the government is reportedly encouraging them to raise capital for growth, thus reducing its stake. The Centre holds over 75% in Indian Overseas Bank, Central Bank of India, Bank of Maharashtra, Punjab & Sind Bank and UCO Bank.

The CEO said the fundraise could reduce the govt's holding by six percentage points from 92.44% as of September

"For this year, we have board approval of ₹5,000 crore and most approvals are in place. So maybe by the end of this quarter or beginning of the next, we will go to the market to raise capital, depending on the market situation. But this is very much on the table, we are doing it," he said.

IOB plans to strengthen cybersecurity by hiring consultants and increasing technology spending to more than ₹1,800 crore in fiscal year 2027 (FY27) from ₹1,700 crore a year ago and ₹1,400 crore in FY25. The allocation could increase further, he indicated. "We have hired professional consultants who are identifying the gaps, and we are covering the gaps."

IOB monitors its systems round the clock. It has cyber insurance and tightened controls on vendors' access to sensitive systems through standard operating procedure and maker-checker safeguards. The bank has a vendor-risk management department, he added.

IOB posted 56% on-year rise in net profit to ₹1,912 crore in Q2 from ₹1,226 crore a year ago, it said on Monday. For H1 FY27, net profit rose 53% to ₹3,572 crore. Domestic net interest margin stood at 3.49% in the quarter, compared with 3.35% a year earlier and 3.48% in the June quarter.

Domestic net interest margin (NIM) stood at 3.49% in the September quarter, compared with 3.35% a year earlier and 3.48% in the June quarter. Global NIM was 3.37%, against 3.21% a year earlier and unchanged sequentially.

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Dalmia Bharat bears brunt of low demand, high costs in Q2

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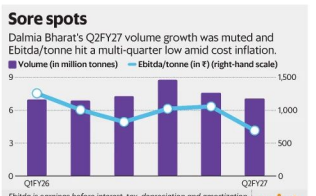
Dalmia Bharat Ltd stock fell 6.5% on Tuesday to a new 52-week low of ₹1,502, after a disappointing September quarter (Q2FY27) triggered earnings downgrades. Volumes rose 3% year-on-year to 7.1 million tonnes, impacted by muted demand in the East and North-East. It lagged the industry's estimated 9-10% growth, pointing to market share loss.

Despite cost-saving efforts, Q2 Ebitda fell 29% on-year to ₹493 crore, missing consensus estimates. Profitability was hit by weak volumes, sequentially lower realizations and input cost inflation. Ebitda per tonne slid to a multi-quarter low of ₹694. Fuel costs are expected to add ₹75-80 per tonne in Q3, while ramping up the acquired Jaiprakash Associates cement assets could add another ₹100-125 per tonne. Antique Stock Broking cut its FY27-29 Ebitda estimates by 7-11% and cautioned that the profitability gap versus peers is likely to widen.

Dalmia expects improving cement prices in its key eastern and southern markets, along with operating leverage, to partly offset the pressure. It sees Ebitda per tonne potentially recovering to ₹1,000 in Q3, provided price hikes of around ₹15 per bag sustain, alongside benefits from

Sore spots

Dalmia Bharat's Q2FY27 volume growth was muted and Ebitda/tonne hit a multi-quarter low amid cost inflation.



Ebitda is earnings before interest, tax, depreciation and amortization
Source: Company, Nirmal Bang Institutional Equities

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MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

improved fixed-cost absorption and a better regional mix. It is hopeful of a demand recovery and volume growth in line with the industry at 7-8% in H2FY27, aided by timely capacity additions.

It is on track to reach 67 mtpa of grinding capacity by the end of FY28, with Belgaum, Pune and Kadapa scheduled to be commissioned in Q4FY27, Q2FY28 and H2FY28, respectively. Its expanding capacity base, including central India assets, strengthens its pan-India presence, but capacity utilization needs to improve.

"Over FY21-FY26, capacity grew at a 10% CAGR, outpacing volume growth of 7.7%, highlighting the importance of improving utilization," said Nirmal Bang Institutional Equities. Capacity utilization at 62%/61% in FY25/FY26 and 58% in H1FY27 was below industry levels, it added.

Of the FY27 capital expenditure goal of ₹3,200-3,400 crore, ₹1,420 crore was spent in H1. Leverage has inched up amid capacity expansions. Net debt rose to ₹5,722 crore, taking net-debt/Ebitda to 2x from 1.5x in Q1. It is committed to maintaining net-debt/Ebitda below 2x on a sustainable basis.

So far in 2026, the stock is down 29%, trading at an FY28 EV/Ebitda multiple of 9.37x, in line with its five-year average, showed *Bloomberg* data. But the scope for a re-rating is low.

Mark to Market writers do not hold positions in the companies discussed here unless otherwise informed

CG Power has rallied 29%, but analysts are still raising bets

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CG Power and Industrial Solutions has rallied 29% in 2026, and its latest earnings have given investors further reason for optimism. The bullishness around the stock goes beyond a strong quarter and a rising share price.

India's push to modernize its power grid, expand transmission networks and ramp up industrial capital expenditure is creating a multi-year growth opportunity for electrical equipment makers, with CG Power well-positioned to capitalize on the trend, according to analysts.

CG Power's consolidated net profit surged 44% to ₹409.09 crore in the September quarter (Q2 FY27), up from ₹284.44 crore a year ago. Revenue from operations rose 30% year-on-year to ₹3,801.54 crore.

CG Power's consolidated net profit surged 44% to ₹409.09 crore in Q2 FY27, up from ₹284.44 crore a year ago

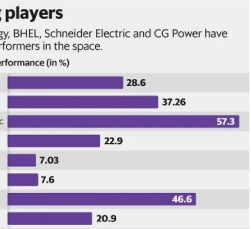
Analysts have taken note, raising earnings estimates, upgrading ratings and initiating coverage as they reassess the company's growth potential.

According to *Bloomberg* data, 21 analysts have a 'buy' rating on CG Power, while two have a 'hold' rating and two recommend selling the stock.

Nomura, in its 23 October report, raised its FY28-29 earnings-per-share estimates by 4% after the power systems segment outperformed in Q2FY27. It reaffirmed its 'buy' rating with a target price of ₹1,100. Emkay Global Financial Services remains positive on CG Power's long-term prospects, citing its strong product portfolio and execution track record. However, given the stock's premium valuation, it retained its 'add' rating and target price of ₹925 in its 25 October report. Dolat Capital, meanwhile, sees an opportunity after the stock corrected 17% from its July 2026 high, making valuations more attractive. It upgraded the stock to 'buy' from 'accumulate', while retaining its target price of ₹1,000, in its 24 October report.

Leading players

Hitachi Energy, BHEL, Schneider Electric and CG Power have been top performers in the space.



Source: Bloomberg

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Order book remains strong while emerging businesses of semiconductor design and manufacturing are future growth drivers, said Sunny Agrawal, head-fundamental research, SBI Securities.

He added that medium-term fair value lies between ₹950 and ₹980. However, slowdown in artificial intelligence (AI) capex could impact near-term sentiment on the stock.

CG Power and Industrial Solutions shares ended 0.24% higher at ₹835 on BSE, while the Sensex fell 0.01%.

YES Securities has initiated coverage on CG Power and Industrial with a 'buy' rating and a target price of ₹985. Harsh Tewaney, lead analyst at YES Securities, sees CG Power as a key beneficiary of the massive grid infrastructure buildout, which has a clear visibility until FY36. He explained CG leads the low-tension motors market with a 38-39% share and holds 19-20% of the larger industrial motors market.

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Yes Bank AT-1 holders seek verdict compliance

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Yes Bank Ltd's additional tier-1 (AT-1) bondholders have written to the government and financial market regulators seeking timely implementation of a recent Supreme Court judgment in their favour.

The Yes Bank AT-1 Bond Holders Association on Tuesday wrote separately to the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) and the finance ministry, seeking time-bound action. The letters sought the restoration of investors' written-down principal, payment of coupons and interest legally due, and clear implementation timelines from Yes Bank and relevant authorities. It has sought written responses from RBI and Sebi within 15 days, while asking the finance ministry to coordinate a time-bound response across institutions.

"The Supreme Court has given the judgment in our favour, dismissing the appeals. We want RBI and Sebi to step in and enforce their own regulatory role," said Saurabh, a member of the association whose parents hold these bonds. He said the association wants the bank to restore the principal and pay interest.

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India Inc's profit rebound faces fresh test

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Indian companies posted their fastest profit growth in over two years in the September quarter, but much of the gain came off a weak base, while surging oil, freight and metal prices threaten to squeeze margins from the December quarter.

Mint's analysis of 356 companies' standalone results shows that net profit rose 27% year-on-year in the second quarter (Q2 FY27), compared with a 9% rise in the year-ago quarter. This was the cohort's strongest profit growth in 10 quarters, even as input costs climbed to multi-quarter highs.

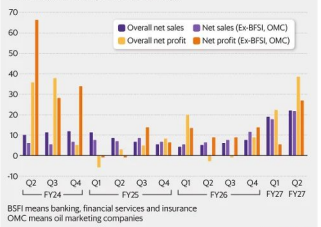
Elevated oil, freight and metal prices threaten to push up costs for companies across sectors in the coming months. While some businesses have raised prices to protect margins, their ability to pass on further increases varies, setting the stage for a more uneven earnings performance in the coming quarters.

Experts attribute part of the Q2 recovery to a sharp turnaround in oil marketing companies (OMCs), which swung from a cumulative loss of nearly ₹13,600 crore in the June quarter to a profit of around ₹12,700 crore in the September quarter. OMCs accounted for 6.7% of the overall Q2 profit pool.

The turnaround was supported by relatively subdued crude prices for much of the quarter, price increases of ₹3-8 per litre for petrol and diesel by state-owned fuel retailers, and government compensation for losses on subsidized liquefied petroleum gas sales.

In the fast lane

Year-on-year change (%) in earnings.



BSFI means banking, financial services and insurance
OMC means oil marketing companies

Source: Ace Equity, Mint analysis

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But this improvement may prove temporary, cautioned Prashant Shah, co-founder and chief executive of Definedge Securities, as refiners' profitability remains highly sensitive to oil price movements.

"Crude has been extremely volatile, and managements have said it is difficult to give a clear outlook in this environment," he said. With Brent crude back near a six-month high of $115 a barrel, the outlook for OMCs and corporate India broadly remains challenging.

Elevated oil, freight and metal prices threaten to push up costs for companies across sectors in the coming months

Elevated oil, freight and metal prices have pushed up business costs, prompting companies to raise prices by 10-30% over the past six months through repeated small increases, said Prasenjit Paul, fund manager at 129 Wealth and head of research at Paul Asset. Higher prices and realizations have lifted a significant share of India Inc's Q2 revenue, he added.

The 356 companies analysed by *Mint* reported a 22% on-year rise in net sales, their strongest topline growth in at least three years. However, companies' ability to pass on higher costs varies across sectors and could emerge as a key differentiator between winners and losers, Paul said.

Experts expect airlines, tire manufacturers, OMCs, cement makers and chemical firms to face mounting pressure on profit margins.

Firms that sell to other businesses under contracts with built-in cost-adjustment clauses are better protected, Shah said. Consumer-facing companies, by contrast, face greater pressure from competition and delays in raising prices, he added.

Against this backdrop, auto ancillary companies and capital goods makers linked to power transmission and distribution stand out. Auto ancillary companies have reported an 83% year-on-year rise in net profit in Q2 so far, while electrical capital goods makers have more than doubled their profits.

Despite their exposure to cyclical automobile demand, auto ancillary companies have diversified into segments such as railways, defence and precision engineering, Paul said. The shift towards higher-value, specialized products is creating pockets of structural growth beyond the traditional automotive cycle, he added.

Electrical capital goods makers are similarly benefiting from a surge in data centre investments, which is driving demand for power transmission and distribution infrastructure, Paul said. These structural tailwinds and robust end-market demand appear to be helping both segments sustain earnings growth despite rising cost pressures. "Both segments could see a further expansion in profitability if commodity prices ease and provide relief on input costs."

Firms excluding BFSI and OMCs have reported a net profit margin of 14.4% so far, down from Q1's 15.3% but above the four-year average of 13.4%.

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Auto makers warn of rural distress

A weak monsoon in many parts of the country is likely to dampen demand and sales of cars and two-wheelers, besides tractors

Commodity prices hurt Maruti

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Maruti is monitoring rural demand following deficient monsoon rains, though festive sales remain unaffected so far. MINT

Maruti Suzuki has warned that weak monsoon rains could weigh on rural demand just as India's largest carmaker grapples with a third consecutive quarterly decline in profit, highlighting the pressure on earnings even as vehicle sales remain strong.

The New Delhi-based firm on Tuesday reported a 26% year-on-year drop in net profit to ₹2,466 crore for the July-September quarter of fiscal year 2027 (Q2FY27), hurt by higher commodity prices, rising logistics costs, and investments to expand capacity.

Earnings before interest, tax, depreciation and amortization (Ebitda) margin fell by more than three percentage points to 9.4%, underscoring the squeeze on profitability. Revenue, however, rose 26% to ₹53,356 crore, while total sales volume increased 27% to 696,654 units, buoyed by growth in domestic and export markets.

Maruti Suzuki is watching for signs of a slowdown in rural demand due to deficient monsoon rains in some states, though the company has yet to see an impact during the ongoing festive season.

"Some of the states are facing stress (owing to El Niño effect). Rajasthan, MP, Karnataka, I am aware of it. So I would say let's wait and watch. But so far, we are not seeing the impact because it is festival time," Partho Banerjee, senior executive officer of marketing and sales, said during a post-results media conference.

"The response is pretty good. Right now, we have got a pending orderbook of almost 2.65 lakhs. In times to come, we have to wait and watch. Maybe there could be some stress coming from the rural market," Banerjee noted.

Earlier this year, tractor makers warned that the potential impact of El Niño on the monsoon could hurt sales growth by affecting farmers' earnings.

For now, Maruti remains upbeat about near-term demand, despite a tougher year-on-year comparison following last year's goods and services tax (GST) cuts, which took effect on 22 September 2025.

"Currently, we are maintaining a good momentum," Hisashi Takeuchi, managing director and chief executive at Maruti Suzuki, said during the post results media conference. "Although last year's base is very high after September because of GST cuts. But still, we are maintaining, I think, over and above last year's sales numbers. So I think we are pretty positive about the near future."

The firm's pending order book of nearly 265,000 units offers some visibility on demand in coming months.

Maruti has raised prices three times so far in 2026 to offset rising input costs and expects further increases over the next two quarters, depending on commodity price movements.

Dealers have warned that repeated price hikes could weigh on sales by making vehicles less affordable, particularly as financing costs rise.

The company is also stepping up efforts to control costs and shore up margins after several quarters of declining profitability.

Chief financial officer Arnab Roy said the sequential improvement in Ebitda margin, from 8.6% in the June quarter to 9.4% in September, indicated that some recovery was already under way. Maruti is also seeking to contain marketing and other expenses to offset cost pressures.

Automakers' commentary on costs and demand is being closely watched as India contends with elevated inflation and a high base of vehicle sales following last year's GST cuts.

Maruti is the first carmaker to report its fiscal second-quarter results, with Hyundai Motor India, Mahindra and Mahindra, and Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles Ltd scheduled to follow over the next two weeks.

SALES SURGE, PROFITS SLIDE

MARUTI'S pending order book stood at 265,000 vehicles, offering visibility on near-term demand

MD Hisashi Takeuchi said it's optimistic on demand despite a high base following last year's GST cuts

IT has raised prices three times in 2026 to offset rising input costs; expects more hikes in near future

DEALERS warned that repeated price hikes could weigh on sales, particularly as financing costs rise

Yet, exports and EV sales help boost profits at Bajaj Auto

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Bajaj Auto's net profit surged 62% year-on-year to ₹3,436 crore in Q2FY27, while revenue rose 60% to ₹25,125 crore. MINT

Bajaj Auto's profit surged 62% year-on-year in the July-September quarter as strong export growth, a favourable exchange-rate movement and improving electric-vehicle margins helped India's fourth-largest two-wheeler maker absorb rising commodity and logistics costs. But the company flagged emerging signs of rural distress that could weigh on demand.

The Pune-based automaker on Tuesday reported a net profit of ₹3,436 crore, while revenue rose 60% from a year earlier ₹25,125 crore. Growth was driven by global demand, while domestic two-wheeler sales remained subdued.

The company's outlook for rural demand was less upbeat. Rakesh Sharma, joint managing director at Bajaj Auto, warned that weak monsoon rains could deepen stress in parts of the country, echoing concerns raised earlier in the day by Maruti Suzuki, India's largest carmaker. "South India, Maharashtra of course and parts of Northeast are facing difficult times," Sharma said during the earnings call.

Q2 RESULTS

Demand across the two-wheeler market is increasingly skewed towards premium models with engine capacities above 150cc, while lower-capacity motorcycles are underperforming, Sharma said.

"This K-shaped growth which is happening means that people who are doing well are doing even better. People who have got assets, whether it is house or liquid assets in the stock market, are doing very well and they are feeling optimistic enough to spend," he said.

"People who are completely dependent on short-term cash flows income and expense matches, they are facing the inflationary heat," he added.

Bajaj Auto's domestic two-wheeler sales rose 2% to 607,416 units in the second quarter of fiscal year 2027 (Q2FY27), while international sales climbed 43% to 676,545 units. A stronger dollar against the rupee in recent months also helped the company offset industry-wide cost inflation.

The company's shares rose 3.17% on Tuesday after the results were released, compared with a 1.48% gain in the Nifty Auto index. The stock closed at ₹10,390 apiece.

Bajaj Auto said rising costs had gathered pace during the quarter, spreading beyond commodities to electronic components and polymers as the West Asia war disrupted supply chains.

"Costs between Q1 and Q2 have gone up by 7 percentage points and they first started with commodity stuff then into electronic products and polymers because of the war," Sharma said at a post-results media conference.

The company partly offset the increase through price hikes in markets where competitive conditions allowed, as well as dollar-denominated export revenue. "There's a very significant share of business which comes from overseas in US dollars so that mitigated the inflation.

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Just Dial bets big on software to deepen merchant engagement

Agnidev Bhattacharya & Soumya Gupta
MUMBAI

Dinkar Ayilavarapu, chief executive officer, Just Dial.

Just Dial Ltd, Reliance Group's business listings and search platform, plans to focus on helping consumers discover merchants rather than investing in order fulfilment infrastructure, as it revamps its core offerings, a top company executive told *Mint*.

The company, which generates most of its revenue from paid listings and subscriptions, is testing new merchant software products to expand its offerings, its chief executive Dinkar Ayilavarapu said. "The products are in the lab, but they have been tested with hundreds of merchants. Initial responses are awesome. It will come out into the world sooner rather than later."

Ayilavarapu, a Bain & Co. veteran, joined Just Dial in July after leading strategy at Flipkart and heading its B2B arm, Flipkart Wholesale. The company aims to grow its merchant base and average revenue per user (Arpu) by adding software tools to its traditional paid search listings, he said.

While commerce platforms have spent the past five years building transaction capabilities, Just Dial does not plan to expand further into B2B commerce or business-to-consumer commerce marketplace models involving returns and logistics. Instead, it will focus on what Ayilavarapu calls "Discovery plus plus".

The revamp will go beyond software upgrades to include exploring low entry-level pricing to expand the base of paying small and medium business users. "We are anchored in discovery, and have a huge B2C merchant base. We run a lightweight subscription model rather than a heavy marketplace model with returns and fulfillment logistics. As a 10,000+ employee company, we stay true to our core competencies," he added.

Just Dial shares fell 1.4% to close at ₹688.45 apiece on the BSE on Tuesday.

Once a dominant player as India's premier telephone-based directory, the platform struggled to sustain consumer mindshare as the digital landscape shifted toward hyper-specialized mobile phone applications.

Reliance acquired Just Dial in 2021 via Reliance Retail Ventures Ltd. Just Dial's board of directors now includes Ashwin Khasgiwala, chief of business operations at Reliance Retail, and Anshuman Thakur, who heads strategy and planning at Jio Platforms.

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SC reinforces finality of resolution plans

Yash Tiwari & Krishna Yadav
MUMBAI/NEW DELHI

The SC rejected lenders' argument for withdrawing the TD Toll Road plan to secure better recoveries through fresh bids. MINT

The Supreme Court on Monday ruled that lenders cannot withdraw an approved insolvency resolution plan merely because a company's financial position has improved, potentially limiting creditors' ability to seek better commercial terms.

A division bench of Justices J.B. Pardiwala and K. Vinod Chandran declined to interfere with the National Company Law Tribunal's (NCLT) order rejecting the committee of creditors' (CoC) attempt to withdraw the resolution plan for TD Toll Road, a subsidiary of Reliance Infrastructure Ltd.

The bench remarked that under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC), neither the CoC nor the resolution applicant can withdraw the approved resolution merely by stating that certain developments have made the transaction less attractive.

"We are of the opinion that the withdrawal of an application can only be till the CoC approves the plan, and after it is placed before the Adjudicating Authority, there can be no withdrawal either of the application or the approved resolution plan," stated the order.

The ruling offers certainty to resolution applicants, who commit capital and furnish bank guarantees while awaiting approval of their plans, said Anoop Rawat, partner and national practice head for insolvency and restructuring at Shardul Amarchand Mangaldas & Co. "Bidders commit capital, provide bank guarantees and wait through long approval periods. They need to know that the price agreed will not be reopened because the business later recovers," he said.

SC said improved profitability can't justify rejecting a resolution plan that meets all statutory requirements

Although commercial wisdom protects the CoC from judicial scrutiny, that does not empower them to reconsider their own approved plan, according to Yash Dhruva, a partner at MDP Legal Advocates and Solicitors. "The CoC cannot invoke commercial wisdom to undo that decision... commercial wisdom protects CoC's decision from judicial second-guessing, but does not give it indefinite right to reconsider its approved decision," he said.

Mukesh Chand, senior counsel, Economic Laws Practice, said instances of the CoC seeking to withdraw approved resolution plan are rare. But, "the ruling would put an end to the reopening of resolution plans, as it places the CoC and other stakeholders on an equal footing with the resolution applicant regarding the binding nature of the plan," he said.

TD Toll Road's financials deteriorated during covid-19. A ₹172.55 crore resolution plan was subsequently approved, while the company had a cash balance of about ₹30 crore.

The CoC, comprising six lenders, including Bank of India, Canara Bank, Union Bank of India, UCO Bank and Punjab National Bank, unanimously sought to withdraw the plan and invite fresh bids, arguing that the company's improved financial position could yield better recoveries.

The lenders argued that by the time the litigation concluded, the company's balance had risen to ₹165 crore, giving the resolution applicant a substantial financial advantage.

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For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

BWH eyes small-town unbranded hotel assets for growth

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As hotel chains look beyond India's major cities for growth, BWH Hotels is seeking to add more independent hotels in smaller towns to its global network, betting that improved infrastructure will drive demand for branded accommodation.

The company is also bringing three hotel groups—WorldHotels, Best Western Hotels & Resorts and SureStay Hotels—under a common umbrella to make its range of properties, from luxury to budget stays, more recognizable to travellers and hotel owners. The groups will retain their distinct identities.

"Smaller towns are coming into focus...because of infrastructure. Possibility of conversions is quite large. Many such properties are already there, which are unbranded and can be brought on board," Atul Jain, chief operating officer for India, Bangladesh and Sri Lanka at BWH Hotels, said.

It expects greater opportunities to work with existing hotels in these markets rather than depend on new undeer-construction properties. Independent hotels benefit from an international brand, access to a wider pool of travellers and a hotel company's booking and marketing systems, Jain said.

The move to rebrand global business will strengthen BWH Hotels' India expansion plans. *Mint* reported in February that it is eyeing 100 hotels in India by FY30, with focus on religious destinations and towns benefiting from better highway connectivity. It runs 34 hotels in India and has another 26 in its pipeline, added Jain.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Premium *mithai* brands making a beeline for luxury gifting market

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Premium sweets are getting a Diwali makeover, with gift boxes featuring gold-leaf pista katli and unusual flavours. HT

A box of 30 pista *katlis* finished with a 24-karat gold foil priced at ₹21,000 from Khoya Mithai. A festive pack of 36 assorted sinful sweets at Meetha by Radisson for ₹3,999, with no added preservatives. Melt-in-the-mouth ingredients bringing Biscoff *barfis* and mango *thandai pedas* by Mithai by Rosette, priced at ₹2,000 each for 16 pieces. Familiar sweet boxes are getting a mega-luxury makeover this *Diwali*.

A tiny sliver of the ₹84,310 crore Indian sweets market—possibly 0.5%—is occupied by luxury sweets. Premium sweet makers are using unusual flavours, expensive ingredients and elaborate packaging to turn traditional sweets into gifts that cost several thousand rupees a box, or several hundred rupees apiece.

With Diwali just round the corner, brands such as Khoya, Hyderabad's Almond House, Delhi's Arq Mithai, Ikai in Mumbai and Bombay Sweet House are stepping up their festive offerings, while hotel groups are trying to turn their *mithai* into consumer brands beyond their properties.

The opportunity is not just in selling big corporate hampers. Individual customers are becoming an important source of demand, too, as they buy premium boxes for family, friends and business associates, often ordering up to 100 boxes, companies said.

Corporate orders are up 10-15% from last year, but individual buyers are the strongest segment, Sid Mathur, founder and director of Khoya Mithai, said. The company expects the coming days to be particularly and the stakes are high. "The two-month period—15 days before and after Diwali—accounts for 35-40% of its annual revenue."

The company is betting that more consumers will trade up from conventional *mithai* to branded sweets and curated hampers. Though official data is unavailable, Mathur estimates premium sweets account for less than 1% of the overall market. The gap between the small premium segment and the vast Indian sweets market has attracted newer players. But Mathur said their entry was expanding luxury mithais rather than threatening the established players.

SWEET LUXURY

PREMIUM sweets account for 0.5% of India's ₹84,310 crore sweets market, show industry estimates

INDIVIDUAL buyers are a key demand driver, ordering up to 100 boxes for family, friends & colleagues

"We were the pioneers, but we don't really see it as a threat, it's more like a widening of the base," he said.

The company's festive range includes gold-leaf pista katli, jaggery-sweetened kaju katli and dry-fruit laddoos, alongside products such as nut butters and masala aam papad. Its 16-piece mithai box, weighing half a kg, costs ₹1,800; a 36-piece box weighing more than 1 kg is priced at ₹3,600.

Manam Chocolate, which sells chocolate gifting boxes priced at ₹1,600 to ₹10,000, sees healthy online sales and pre-bookings, said Chaitanya Muppala, founder of Manam Chocolate + Distinct Origins and CEO of Almond House. Its sweet spot is about ₹3,000.

Manam's individual orders are a larger pie than corporate employee-gifting. Window for orders of thousands of boxes has passed, while small business orders of 10-30 boxes, are still coming in, he added.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Ahammune chases vitiligo cure

Pune-based Ahammune Biosciences believes the answer to treating vitiligo could lie in intervening before the immune system launches its attack

Jessica Jani
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MUMBAI

Every day, specialized cells in the skin produce melanin, the pigment that gives skin its colour. In people with vitiligo, a trigger can cause the cells to send out a distress signal. The immune system turns against these cells, destroying them and leaving behind patches of skin that lose their pigment.

Existing cures involve suppressing the immune system or even targeting the distress signal pathway.

The biggest piece of the puzzle is: what triggers the cell to release a distress signal in the first place?

Pune-based Ahammune Biosciences believes the answer could lie in intervening before the immune system launches its attack.

mint LAB RATS

For chief executive Parul Ganju, an effective treatment must do more than halt the disease. It should stop the patches from spreading, restore pigmentation and ensure that the colour does not fade again.

After a decade of research, Ahammune has advanced its lead candidate, AB1001, to phase 2 clinical trials, with a team of just 10 and $8-9 million raised through grants and equity funding.

"That's what has helped us in the last ten years to take the molecule into phase 2, at a fraction of the cost that any company outside India would spend," Ganju said.

In drug development, phase 1 trials are focused primarily on establishing safety, tolerability and dose range in healthy volunteers, before they can progress to phase 2, tested in a larger group of patients to see how it works while still remaining safe.

While there has been a rising interest in Indian biotech funding, Ganju characterized it as investors "still testing the waters...Because there's still less understanding of how commercialization is going to take place in the long term."

What does its drug do?

"We identified a pathway that leads to the trigger of this autoimmunity in the skin. And then we designed molecules to target this pathway," said Ganju.

Its lead molecule, AB1001, is a first-in-class drug, meaning a completely new mechanism of action to treat a disease. It has already progressed further than most other Indian discovery-stage molecules and is currently in phase 2 clinical trials across the country.

In drug development, phase 1 trials are focused primarily on establishing safety, tolerability and dose range in healthy volunteers, before they can progress to phase 2, tested in a larger group of patients to see how it works while still remaining safe.

Existing treatments include topical corticosteroid creams, oral steroids, as well as a new class of drugs called JAK inhibitors, which target the cellular messaging pathways after the autoimmune response has been triggered.

Steroidal treatments suppress the immune system, arresting the spread of patches. In early stages, some creams can also help restore colour. However, they have significant side-effects.

JAK inhibitors like Ruxolitinab, which is the first US Food and Drug Administration-approved JAK treatment for non-segmental vitiligo, can also have severe side-effects, especially the oral drugs, including major adverse cardiovascular events, blood clots, serious infections and cancer.

"If you think of what attributes a good vitiligo treatment should have, there should ideally be three attributes: one, it should stop the spread of the patches...Second is also bringing back colour to these patches so that they become even to your skin tone, and third is when they come back, they remain like that," said Ganju.

The molecule that Ahammune has identified addresses all three.

Its drug candidate is not an immunosuppressant and has passed the safety check in its phase 1 trials, which is crucial in long-term treatments.

Currently, it is being developed as a topical cream, but an oral medicine is in early stages of development as well. It's also working on two other programmes that target skin-related autoimmune disorders, which are in the pre-clinical stage.

The cornerstone of Ahammune's strategy going forward is to keep the therapy affordable for Indian patients. "We want to take it all the way to commercialization on our own for the Indian market, while pursuing partnerships for the US and European markets, considering that we have patents in place," said Ganju, emphasizing that accessibility remains a core focus.

Currently in India, for early stages, doctors prescribe generic versions of steroid creams like Elocon and Tenovate, which cost about ₹100-300 for a 10g tube.

On the other hand, the newer therapies like the JAK inhibitors can cost about ₹15,000 for a 15g tube, according to prices listed on online pharmacies.

Next round of funding

Ahammune is now looking at its next round of funding as it expands its team and deepens its strategy.

"The idea is to choose areas which have not had any sort of huge interest from the clinical fraternity to do research... The things that Ahammune is trying to do have a huge use case. There are many, many patients across the world, yet not enough clinical research has happened. So, we have taken that path," said Uday Chatterjee, Ahammune board member and angel investor.

Success would open a lot of doors for large investments, both from national and international sources, Chatterjee added. "Which is definitely the lifeblood, because without a large infusion of capital, you cannot do this work. So what they're doing has in that sense a very vital importance to the future of this development," he said.

This is the third in a six-part Mint series on biotech startups.

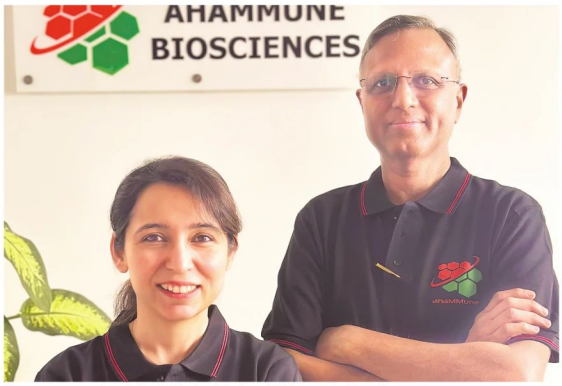
SKIN TEST

EXISTING cures involve suppressing the immune system or targeting distress signal pathway

FOR chief executive Parul Ganju, an effective treatment must do more than halt the disease

AFTER a decade of research, Ahammune has advanced its lead candidate, AB1001, to phase 2 clinical trials

AB1001 is a first-in-class drug, meaning a completely new mechanism of action to treat a disease



Ahammune was co-founded in 2016 by Parul Ganju and Krishnamurthy Natarajan.

Recent big-ticket deals

Broad oral small molecules (JAK inhibitors) and injectable biologics have fetched large valuations

Acquirer	Target	When	Size	Molecule/ platform	Indications
argenx	Forte Biosciences	Jul 2026	Up to $2.2 billion	FB102	Vitiligo & autoimmune disorders
Johnson & Johnson	Yellow Jersey Therapeutics (Numab subsidiary)	Jul 2024	$1.25 billion	NM26*	Atopic dermatitis and inflammatory skin
Incyte	Escient Pharmaceuticals	Apr 2024	$750 million	EP262*	Atopic dermatitis & chronic urticaria
SUN PHARMA	Concert Pharmaceuticals	Mar 2023	~$576 million	Deuruxolitinib (Oral JAK inhibitor)	Alopecia areata
abbvie	Nimble Therapeutics	Dec 2024	$200 million upfront	Peptide technology platform & preclinical assets	Plaque psoriasis & dermatology

*Discontinued phase 2 trials for both; Deal type: Acquisition

Source: Mint research

PRATEEK KUMAR/MINT

L&T Q2 signals smooth sailing amid upheavals

FROM PAGE 1

L&T reported ₹78,750 crore revenue during the quarter, 16% higher year-on-year. Profit grew by a third to ₹4,878 crore.

However, earnings before interest, tax, depreciation and amortization (Ebitda) were flat at ₹6,845 crore.

Ebitda margin narrowed 1.3 percentage points to 8.7%, something the company blamed on cost escalations and execution delays in West Asia.

L&T reported ₹78,750 crore revenue in the quarter. REUTERS

The management reassured investors that some of the cost escalations would be contractually passed through to clients, but that will happen with a lag; so, some of the eroded margins should return in subsequent quarters.

The company outlined a pipeline of about ₹10 trillion of projects that it plans to bid for. Typically, between a fourth and a fifth of the company's bids turn successful, giving sufficient business visibility.

"The numbers are definitely better than expected, given the geopolitical context. We were expecting revenue growth to be slower, but the company maintained its execution, resulting in good topline growth. The margins are under pressure, but that is largely restricted to the infrastructure segment," said Amit Anwani, vice-president and lead analyst for capital goods, industrials and defence at brokerage PL Capital.

The infrastructure giant outlined a pipeline of about ₹10 trillion of projects that it plans to bid for

"It can be called a broadly stable to good quarter. We have maintained our projections," he said.

The L&T management noted that execution in its water segment, with orders worth about ₹40,000 crore, had slowed down due to the weak finances of Indian states.

The company was only proceeding with work when it was assured of payments getting cleared, resulting in frequent start-stop in execution.

Overall order flows from the domestic market remained strong, the management said, with over a third of its new orders during the quarter coming from India.

Clients, especially in the Middle East, were amenable to reimbursing the company for some of the cost escalations, Raman said, which would be captured in future margins. "The margins that you don't see today are margins deferred than margins lost," he said.

The company painted a sanguine business outlook given India's resilient macroeconomic indicators despite a plethora of global crises. Artificial intelligence (AI) data centre demand and fresh investments in infrastructure and energy transition across geographies were highlighted as opportunities for the company.

It flagged inflation as a concern. The conflict in West Asia posed additional downside risk.

Shares of Larsen & Toubro Ltd closed 0.19% lower on the BSE at ₹3,670 on Tuesday, while the benchmark Sensex closed flat.

JLR bets on local assembly, EVs to defend India luxury car ranking

Nehal Chaliawala & Ayaan Kartik
MUMBAI/NEW DELHI

Jaguar Land Rover (JLR) is stepping up localization and preparing to introduce four electric vehicles (EVs) in India over the next year, seeking to strengthen its position in the country's luxury car market as German rivals gain ground through locally assembled models and rising electric-car sales.

The Tata Motors Passenger Vehicle Ltd-owned British carmaker will begin assembling its best-selling Defender at its Pune-area plant within a fortnight, extending domestic assembly to almost its entire portfolio, the company said on Tuesday. The move is expected to reduce the prices of the sport utility vehicle (SUV) by up to 20%, potentially helping the company widen its customer base and compete more aggressively with market leaders Mercedes-Benz and BMW.

The British carmaker will begin assembling its best-selling Defender at its Pune-area plant within a fortnight. REUTERS

"India is a high-growth market for us. Yes the volumes are low, but we see a lot more potential in this market," Rajan Amba, managing director of Jaguar Land Rover India, said at a media interaction in Mumbai on Tuesday.

Jaguar Land Rover will assemble the Defender's highest-selling 110 trim using knocked-down kits imported from Slovakia. The 90 and 130 trims will continue to be imported as completely built units (CBUs) from the European country.

The company already assembles popular models such as the Range Rover and Discovery at its facility near Pune. With the Defender joining them, all its models will be assembled in India, barring a few trims, Amba said. The company also imports some vehicles from its manufacturing facilities in England, which now attract lower duties under the India-UK free trade agreement.

The Defender localization plan has been in the works for some time. About a year and a half ago, the company's management said it was shaping plans to manufacture the SUV in India to benefit from lower import duties on completely knocked-down (CKD) kits, at around 16%, compared with tariffs of up to 110% on CBUs.

The push mirrors the strategy of Mercedes-Benz and BMW, which assemble almost their entire portfolios in India

The push mirrors the strategy of market leaders Mercedes-Benz and BMW, which assemble almost their entire portfolios at their respective Indian plants. Jaguar Land Rover sold just under 6,000 cars in India in 2025, overtaking Germany's Audi to become the country's third-largest luxury car brand by sales. Mercedes-Benz led with nearly 19,300 units, followed by BMW with more than 17,700.

With the Defender's domestic assembly, Jaguar Land Rover has localized the production of models that account for 95% of its sales, Amba said.

The company plans to follow the Defender's domestic assembly with the launch of up to four EVs over the next year: the Range Rover, Range Rover Sport, a new model called Range Rover GT, and the Jaguar Type 01. The latter will be the first new car from Jaguar under its strategy to become an all-electric brand.

The move comes as German luxury-car makers gain traction in India's electric-vehicle market. BMW is the country's largest luxury EV seller, having sold nearly 2,400 electric cars between January and June this year. One in every four cars it sold in India during the period was electric.

At Mercedes-Benz, more than one in eight cars sold over the same period was electric. EV sales helped BMW narrow the gap with its rival: BMW and Mercedes-Benz sold 9,768 and 9,075 cars, respectively, in the first half of 2026, according to sales data from the companies.

Jaguar Land Rover plans to import its upcoming EVs and has no immediate plans to manufacture them locally, Amba said.

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Sebi's CAS rollback raises hopes of recovery in derivatives

FROM PAGE 1

options (F&O) segment through an auction that established a single equilibrium closing price, replacing the final volume-weighted average price.

"The pre-CAS levels on volumes and revenue seen in Q1 FY27 will be a good indicator of where we are headed once the circular comes into action. However, one may not be able to replicate revenues from earlier since broader market factors also have an effect," a broking official told *Mint* on condition of anonymity.

The auction mechanism quickly lost favour among traders. From 3 August to 30 September, volumes in the closing auction session fell 84% to 4.2 million contracts, while traded value declined 77% to ₹297.72 crore, according to NSE data.

Trading activity, however, began recovering after Sebi issued a consultation paper on 12 September proposing to roll back the framework. The rebound offered an early indication of how market volumes might respond when the revised rules take effect on 7 December.

Between 3 August and 11 September, volumes in Bank Nifty futures fell 7% to 22,691 contracts, while total traded value declined 9% to ₹3,845.53 crore, according to exchange data. By the end of September, however, volumes had recovered to 26,622 contracts, up 9.6%, while traded value rose by 4% to ₹4,408.12 crore.

Nifty futures, however, told a different story. Volumes grew 12% to 62,288 contracts in the initial period through 11 September, before momentum accelerated after the consultation paper to post a 20% gain by month-end at 66,539 contracts. Traded value expanded similarly, stepping up from a 6.4% gain before the consultation paper to an 11% increase by the end of September.

At Angel One, one of India's largest brokers, broking revenue accounted for 55% of consolidated gross revenue in the September quarter of FY27, down from 60% both a year earlier and in the preceding June quarter.

Broking officials said Sebi's latest circular could help brokerage revenues bounce back to levels seen in Q1 of FY27. BLOOMBERG

Groww experienced a similar trend. Broking operations, comprising equity derivatives, cash stocks, and commodity derivatives, contributed 68.4% of total revenue of ₹1,541 crore in the September quarter of FY27, down from 72.9% in the June quarter and 74.9% in the September quarter of FY26.

However, brokers are optimistic about a swift recovery. Two broking officials, speaking on condition of anonymity, said Sebi's latest circular could help brokerage revenues bounce back to levels seen in the first quarter of FY27, before the original CAS framework disrupted trading activity.

"Our expectation is that it (volumes) will go back to normal in some ways. We think that from the day it becomes applicable, the normalization will be much faster. So, we don't expect it (volume) will go up. The way we are expecting is it will normalize the problem that it created," Ishan Bansal, co-founder of Groww, said during the company's earnings call for the September quarter of FY27, which took place before Sebi issued its latest circular in October.

Angel One is also optimistic about the regulatory changes. "The road ahead is also getting clearer with the Sebi circular yesterday evening on updates to the closing auction session. This will bring greater clarity to traders, and we expect that to create some tailwind for us," Ambarish Kenghe, group chief executive officer at Angel One, said during the company's earnings call for the latest quarter.

Amit Majumdar, group chief strategy officer at Angel One, said, "The initial pickup in derivatives activity following the announcement is encouraging, and we expect the improvement in market participation to gather momentum over the coming months."

However, a revival in derivatives activity may not automatically translate into a stronger top line. Over the past year, Indian equities have remained under pressure due to escalating US-Iran geopolitical tensions, weighing heavily on activity across both primary and secondary markets.

"Brokerage revenues have also been influenced by broader market conditions, including periods of heightened volatility and cautious investor sentiment. These conditions have affected trading activity and the pace of new customer acquisition. We believe a more stable market environment, alongside greater clarity in the regulatory framework, should support a gradual recovery in investor participation," Majumdar said.

Snag buys industry time to weigh in on Irdai's proposal

Irdai on Saturday extended deadline for comments on its distributor commission rejig plans

Anshika Kayastha & Samriddhi Mahar
MUMBAI

The Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (Irdai) has extended the deadline for feedback on its proposed overhaul of insurance distributor commissions after a technical glitch disrupted submissions on the final day, according to two industry executives. The extension comes amid resistance from brokers, agents and some insurers, raising questions over whether the regulator can meet its January or April 2027 target for rolling out the final norms.

"Their (Irdai's) website was down since Friday, and Sunday was the last day to submit the feedback. So we brought it to their notice and so they have extended the deadline till 31 October," one of the executives cited above told *Mint*.

Irdai said on Saturday that it had received 650 comments and was extending the deadline to provide additional time "in view of the significant interest and to facilitate wider participation". The six-day extension is unlikely to materially help stakeholders seeking more time to assess the proposals. Last month, the Insurance Brokers' Association of India (IBAI) wrote to Irdai seeking time until 31 December to submit its suggestions, citing the need for detailed impact studies and relevant data.

Issued on 23 September, the consultation paper proposes changes to commission caps, expenses of management (EoM), insurance bundling with loans and motor insurance distribution. The original deadline was 25 October.

The proposals could alter the economics of insurance distribution, with brokers and independent agents warning of business disruption and potential job losses.

A technical glitch had prevented submission of comments on Irdai's proposed overhaul of insurance distributor commissions before the 25 October deadline. MINT

IBAI and the Confederation of General Insurance Agents Association of India (CGIAAD) have written to the finance ministry and the Prime Minister's Office over the past week, seeking government intervention. The Life Insurance Agents' Federation of India (LIAFI) has separately sought higher commissions and transition safeguards, arguing that lower earnings could discourage new entrants into the agency force. "We have requested the PM to intervene and ensure consultation between the regulator and the finance ministry," K.C. Lokessh, convener, told *Mint*. He said the proposals had far-reaching implications that warranted more dialogue between the regulator and industry players.

Lokessh also flagged the lack of policyholder representation in the debate, questioning whether insurers would pass on any benefits to customers. He warned that a decline in independent advisers and brokers could reduce access to advice, while lower agent earnings could encourage volume-driven selling and raise mis-selling risks. There is broad agreement that mis-selling needs to be addressed, but the scope of the proposed intervention is a concern, said Pallavi Malani, managing director and partner at BCG India. "On commissions, a detailed analysis is needed to assess the cost to serve that still allows insurers and distributors to cover the cost of selling and servicing these policies across geographies," Malani said.

A blanket approach, she said, could penalize the industry for problems in particular products, channels, insurers or distributors. "The regulator should therefore look at the data at a more granular level before deciding on the appropriate intervention to solve the root cause of the problem."

Some smaller insurers have also raised concerns that tighter EoM limits could disadvantage newer players, whose operating costs tend to be higher as they build distribution networks and invest in people and tech. EoM covers insurers' operating costs like agent commissions, employee salaries, rent, tech and marketing.

"Insurers are not questioning the direction of the reform. Their concern is pace and how it is applied," said Vivek Ramji Iyer, partner and national leader – Financial Services Risk Advisory, Grant Thornton Bharat.

A uniform, immediate rollout of commission caps alongside a tighter EoM glide path, he said, would leave little room to manage the transition. "For many insurers the cost math works in their favour, but the volume risk and the strain on bank and distributor relationships are real. That is why most are asking for phasing rather than pushing back," he said.

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For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

SIX-DAY EXTENSION

IRDAI extended the deadline for sharing comments on the overhaul till 31 October

THE extension is unlikely to materially help stakeholders seeking more time to assess the proposals

IBAI had in September asked Irdai for time till 31 December to submit its suggestions

LIAFI has separately sought higher commissions and transition safeguards citing lower earnings

TCPL's distribution overhaul powers growth in more areas

Neethi Lisa Rojan
neethi.rojan@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Sunil D'Souza, managing director and chief executive, Tata Consumer Products

Tata Consumer Products Ltd, (TCPL) which sells products ranging from Tetley tea to Himalayan Natural Mineral Water and millet-based products, is seeing its distribution revamp drive growth across more businesses, while boosting core portfolio volumes, managing director and chief executive officer Sunil D'Souza said. "I think we've unlocked our growth by doing the split and segmented distribution right," D'Souza told *Mint*.

Tata Consumer Products completed the overhaul of its distribution strategy earlier in February. In markets where salt accounted for a high share of sales, the company separated distributors handling salt from those handling other products. In markets where both tea and salt had a strong presence, distributors were split between the core and growth portfolios.

The changes helped the company achieve underlying volume growth of 11% in the September quarter from a year earlier, despite price hikes in products such as tea and salt, D'Souza said. Revenue from the salt segment grew 15% year-on-year, while volumes rose 9%. Shares of Tata Consumer rose as much as 6.6% on the National Stock Exchange early on Tuesday, even as the Nifty FMCG index declined 0.08%.

"What that has done, it has not only given a fillip to the growth portfolio by focusing distribution on that, but unlocked growth territory for our salt distributors," he said.

Tata Consumer on Monday reported consolidated group net profit of ₹470.14 crore for Q2FY27

The company's growth businesses, which include ready-to-drink beverages, Tata Sampann, Capital Foods and Organic India, crossed the ₹4,000 crore revenue mark in FY26, growing 24%.

These businesses are emerging as a growth engine for Tata Consumer. They grew 40% in the second quarter and accounted for 38% of the company's India business. The Tata Sampann portfolio, which includes spices, oils and ready-to-cook products, reported year-on-year growth of 57%, driven by volume growth. The company's dry fruits and cold-pressed oils businesses together reported annual recurring revenue of about ₹1,000 crore.

Tata Consumer on Monday reported consolidated group net profit of ₹470.14 crore for the September quarter of FY27, up 15.6% from a year earlier. Consolidated revenue rose 14% year-on-year to ₹5,661.13 crore, the company said in an exchange filing. The company has also raised prices of tea and salt.

"That inflation affects me as much as it affects all the smaller retailers. So it's not that I'm leaving money on the table for the smaller retailers to take," he said.

Consumers are shifting to premium salt varieties, including Himalayan and low-sodium options. Tata Consumer's value-added salt segment grew 17%, D'Souza said.

Consolidated earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation and amortization (Ebitda) margin expanded by 40 basis points to 14% in the September quarter. "Price hikes in salt/tea, cost savings and lower coffee prices could support Ebitda margin expansion in FY27," analysts at ICICI Securities said on 27 October.

However, the broader fast-moving consumer goods (FMCG) sector continues to face demand challenges. D'Souza flagged concerns about the outlook as inflation rises and consumer demand weakens.

"When I look at the external indicators, whether it is inflation moving to 5-6%, food inflation moving to 6-7%, I think Nielsen shows both urban and rural demand now starting to hit negative territories. That's a bit of a worrying prospect for the future," he said.

For an extended version of the story, go to livemint.com

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Statement of Reviewed Financial Results for the quarter and half year ended September 30, 2026

Based on the recommendation of the Audit Committee, the Board of Directors of the Company, at its meeting held on Tuesday, October 27, 2026 has approved the Reviewed Financial Results of the Company for the quarter and half year ended September 30, 2026 (**"Financial Results"**).

Scan to access the detailed Financial Results

Q2FY27 in brief

AUM	Disbursement	Gross NPA	PAT
₹ 18,010 Cr.	₹ 1,705 Cr.	1.7%	₹ 170 Cr.
27.0% 6.3%	32.2% 4.7 %	-20 bps -10 bps	29.1% 6.5%
		YoY	QoQ

The Financial Results, together with the Limited Review Report (with unmodified opinion on the Financial Results) issued by the Joint Statutory Auditors, M/s. B S R & Co. LLP, Chartered Accountants (Firm Registration No. 101248W/W-100022), and M/s. Batliboi & Purohit, Chartered Accountants (Firm Registration No. 101048W), have been hosted on the Company's website (https://homefirstindia.com/investor-relations#financial-results), as well as on the websites of BSE Limited (www.bseindia.com) and the National Stock Exchange of India Limited (www.nseindia.com).

***Note:** The above intimation is in accordance with Regulation 33, with Regulation 47(1) Regulation 52 (8) of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015*

Sd/-
Manoj Viswanathan
Managing Director & CEO

Place: Mumbai
Date: October 27, 2026

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STATEMENT OF AUDITED CONSOLIDATED AND STANDALONE FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER AND HALF YEAR ENDED SEPTEMBER 30, 2026

The Board of Directors of the Company at their Meeting held on October 27, 2026 approved the Audited Consolidated and Standalone Financial Results for the quarter and half year ended September 30, 2026.

The above results have been posted on the Company's website at https://investor.indiamart.com/FinancialResultsStatements.aspx and can be accessed by scanning the QR Code.

For and on behalf of the Board of Directors
IndiaMART InterMESH Limited
Sd/-
Dinesh Chandra Agarwal
(Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer)
DIN No.00191800

Date: October 27, 2026
Place: Noida

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निविदा सूचना/**Tender Notice**

The Corporation invites e-Tenders in two bids system having GeM/Tender GEM/2026/B/8204902 & GEM/2026/B/8205802 for Design, Development, Implementation, Operation, Maintenance and Support of 1) "Unified Digital Portal" and 2) "e-Marketplace Portal" under Mission for Cotton Productivity (Kapas Kanti). Detailed terms & conditions and tender documents be downloaded from our website **https://cotcorp.org.in/** and **https://gem.gov.in/**. The last date for submission of tender is 11.00 A.M. on 18.11.2026 & 11.00 A.M. on 19.11.2026 respectively.

Chief General Manager (IT)

भारतीय रिज़र्व बैंक
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Auction of Government of India Dated Securities for ₹33,000 crore on October 30, 2026

Government of India has announced the sale (re-issue) of following dated securities:

Sr. No.	Nomenclature	Notified amount Nominal (in ₹Crore)	Earmarked for Retail Investors (in ₹Crore)
1	6.20% GS 2029	9,000	450
2	6.57% GS 2033	12,000	600
3	7.63% GS 2056	9,000	450
4	7.50% GOI SGrB 2056	3,000	150

The securities will be sold through Reserve Bank of India, Mumbai Office, Fort, Mumbai - 400001, as per the terms and conditions spelt out in the General Notification F.No.4(2)–B(W&M)/2018, dated March 26, 2025 and the Specific Notification issued in this regard.

The auction will be conducted using **multiple price method** on **October 30, 2026 (Friday)**. The result will be announced on the same day and payment by successful bidders will have to be made on **November 02, 2026 (Monday)**.

Retail investors can participate in the auction on a non-competitive basis as per the Scheme for non-competitive bidding facility. Individual investors can also place bids through the Retail Direct portal (https://rbiretaildirect.org.in).

For further details, please see press release dated **October 26, 2026** on RBI website (www.rbi.org.in).

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GLOBAL INVITATION (Through e-bidding Only)
FOR SELECTION OF TRANSMISSION SERVICE PROVIDER THROUGH TARIFF BASED COMPETITIVE BIDDING (TBCB) PROCESS ON BUILD, OWN, OPERATE AND TRANSFER (BOOT) BASIS FOR 01 (ONE) INTRA – STATE TRANSMISSION PROJECT

REC Power Development and Consultancy Limited, New Delhi, India (a wholly owned subsidiary of REC Limited, a Maharatna Central Public Sector Undertaking) invites proposal for setting up of the below mentioned transmission project through TBCB process on Build, Own, Operate and Transfer (BOOT) basis following single stage two envelope process of "Request for Proposal (RFP)". Interested bidders may refer to the Request for Proposal (RFP) notifications and RFP documents available on our websites **www.recpdcl.in** & **www.recindia.nic.in** w.e.f. 28.10.2026.

The bidders may obtain the RFP documents on all working days between 1030 hours (IST) to 1600 hours (IST) from 28.10.2026 to one day prior to bid submission date on payment of non-refundable fee of Rs. 5,00,000/-(Rupees Five Lakh Only) or US$ 7000 (US Dollars Seven Thousand Only) + 18% GST as per details provided in the RFP document available on the websites **www.recpdcl.in** & **www.recindia.nic.in**.

The Request for Proposal (RFP) documents can also be downloaded from our websites **www.recpdcl.in** & **www.recindia.nic.in**, however, in such cases interested parties can submit Response to RFP only on submission of non-refundable fee of Rs. 5,00,000/-(Rupees Five Lakh Only) or US$ 7000 (US Dollars Seven Thousand Only) + 18% GST as per details provided in the RFP document. The survey report & clarifications to RFP documents shall be issued to those bidders, who have obtained/purchased RFP documents by paying requisite fee. The important timelines in this regard are as follows:

Sr. No.	Name of Project	Last Date for seeking clarifications	Last Date for submission of Response to RFP	Details of Opening of Response to RFP
1.	Evacuation of Power from 3x800MW Thermal Power Plant, Nabinagar (Stage-II), Aurangabad	17.11.2026	30.12.2026 up to 1500 Hrs (IST)	30.12.2026 at 1530 Hrs (IST)

All corrigenda, addenda, amendments, time extensions, etc. to the RFP will be hosted on our websites **www.recpdcl.in** & **www.recindia.nic.in**. Bidders should regularly visit our websites to keep themselves updated.

Note: RECPDCL reserves the right to cancel or modify the process without assigning any reason and without any liability. This is not an offer.

Chief Executive Officer
REC Power Development and Consultancy Ltd.
Core-4, SCOPE Complex, 7, Lodhi Road, New Delhi-110003, India

Bid Process Coordinator: **REC Power Development and Consultancy Limited**
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Anthropic sets up defining moment for Wall Street

Anthropic's IPO lays bare the stark extremes of the multi-trillion-dollar AI boom business model

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

Anthropic's IPO filing offers proof of the billions of dollars in sales per year its products generate, but also puts forth hard questions about its extreme losses,and potential for catastrophic harms specific to cutting-edge AI developers. REUTERS

Anthropic PBC's initial public offering (IPO) is laying bare the stark extremes of the multi-trillion-dollar AI boom business model: astonishing growth paired with uncertainty about demand and the spending required to continue developing the technology. The startup, which publicly filed IPO paperwork on Monday, is poised to be the first major US firm focused solely on building AI software to make its market debut.

The filing offers proof of the billions of dollars in sales per year that Anthropic's products generate, but also puts forth hard questions about its extreme losses, profitability, government intervention and the potential for catastrophic harms that are specific to cutting-edge AI developers.

Just five years into its existence, Anthropic is expected to raise more money in its IPO than any firm in history and overtake Berkshire Hathaway Inc. in market value. Its valuation has surged from $183 billion a little over a year ago to $965 billion in its most recent round, with early expectations that the company could be worth upwards of nearly $2 trillion once it goes public—creating a massive windfall, even for employees and investors who got into the company somewhat late. Its public market performance might cement or capsize Wall Street's confidence in the trillion-dollar AI boom at a moment when investors are increasingly anxious about the borrowing binge underpinning it.

More than any other companies, Anthropic and archrival OpenAI have set the pace for global AI development. Anthropic has also put itself at the center of a complex web of interconnected investments from leading chipmakers and cloud providers that are helping to prop up the entire sector and the US economy. "This will really be investors' first significant opportunity to invest directly in the company that is driving the AI economy," said Gil Luria, head of technology research at DA Davidson. "It's of monumental importance."

At the same time, Anthropic's IPO may shape the prospects for an entire generation of AI startups. It's anticipated to funnel more capital into the ecosystem through what promises to be an almost unparalleled wealth creation event and is expected to open the floodgates for others to go public in the coming months after a period of paralysis for the IPO market. In a sign of Anthropic's influence, investors made the pilgrimage to its San Francisco offices this month to hear executives lay out their vision while a small group of protestors gathered outside, calling to "block the IPO" over concerns about the technology. Public and private markets have closely scrutinized every tidbit of information on Anthropic's business, including its non-standardized revenue figures. And on the eve of Anthropic staffers becoming millionaires, wealth management firm IEQ Capital threw a party for AI investors and employees, according to one person familiar with the matter. The invite-only party promised a performance from DJ Diplo.

"Never have IPOs represented so much to the venture capital industry writ large," said Ravi Viswanathan, founder and managing partner of NewView Capital, about the much-anticipated offerings of Anthropic and, eventually, OpenAI.

> More than any other companies, Anthropic and archrival OpenAI have set the pace for global AI development

Over the years, Wall Street has grown accustomed to a certain Silicon Valley success story. Tech firms, including Amazon.com Inc. and Meta Platforms Inc., spend money to increase their share of the market, then reach an inflection point where they become consistently profitable. Anthropic, by its own account, isn't promising any consistency. "I don't think the economics of this industry work that way," Chief Executive Officer Dario Amodei said in a lengthy podcast interview near the start of the year. It's uniquely challenging to predict future demand for a rapidly evolving technology and that's likely to create added shareholder pressure to generate greater returns on investment. Some, including New York City's comptroller, previously called on Anthropic to pause its IPO until it fully addresses safety risks.

Anthropic intends to use the capital raised from its public offering to fuel investments in chips, data centres and talent to build a technology it believes can reshape the global economy. Though that goal is lofty and far from certain, Anthropic has gained momentum this year thanks to a surge in demand for its Claude AI software to streamline more complex workplace tasks, particularly writing and debugging code. Like other AI firms, however, it is working to prove the broader utility for its products beyond software engineers, who are typically early adopters.

Anthropic, which had over 1,000 percent revenue growth year-over-year in 2025, has since seen that pace temper. The company's revenue hit $16.3 billion in the first half of 2026, according to its IPO filing, a more than 14-fold increase from the same period in the prior year. But as *Bloomberg* previously reported, its revenue rate of growth has since slowed from around 140% to 45% in the second to third quarter in 2026.

The company also faces a concentration of risk: In the first half of 2026, 48% of Anthropic's sales to customers came from three technology firms' cloud marketplaces, some of which are building their own models and may someday wean off of Claude, threatening future sales.

Meanwhile, Anthropic disclosed wild swings in its bottom line, including a net loss of almost $42 billion in 2025 and nearly $81 billion in the first two quarters of this year, easily dwarfing the amount Uber Technologies Inc. burned through annually before going public.

And the Claude chatbot maker said that just since the end of 2025, it has committed to invest a staggering $417 billion, with terms ranging from one year to 20, on computing and infrastructure capacity to support its software.

A core assumption is that Anthropic and its peers will eventually generate stratospheric revenue from more advanced AI software in the years ahead that offsets the immense investments made today. But no one, including Amodei, knows for sure what sales will be in five years, said Aswath Damodaran, professor of finance at New York University's Stern School of Business. "They are just as lost as you or me." Amodei and Anthropic have repeatedly been blindsided by events this year:

A massive surge in demand for its products forced leadership to scramble to line up enough computing resources to keep services running. An unprecedented order from the Trump administration led the company to briefly disable access to its best technologies. And a groundswell of concerns from its own rank-and-file staffers pushed Amodei and Anthropic to publicly reckon with the existential risks of the technology, prompting new confrontations with the White House.

Over the course of almost 100 pages, Anthropic laid out a long list of unique risk factors, ranging from heightened government scrutiny that could slow or derail its ability to release more powerful models—the engine for its entire business—to the possibility that its technology leads to the extinction of the human race. It also faces a crowded field of competitors that are constantly one-upping each other with more powerful and affordable models, including Chinese firms that have allegedly extracted results from Anthropic's software to gain an edge and undercut US rivals on price.

The combination of novel, existential risks and the fact that Anthropic remains a relatively young company make it harder for investors to model the upsides and downsides of the business, according to advisers close to the IPO, who spoke on condition of anonymity for fear of reprisals. Still, as a public company, Anthropic's stock is likely to become the ultimate barometer for the AI boom. Even before its IPO filing, the company's every move was scrutinized by investors. An understated announcement about legal plug-ins helped spark a meltdown for software stocks. Its revenue is closely watched to gauge demand for AI services broadly. Amodei's prognostications have been widely dissected, too.

A former academic, Amodei has released several lengthy treatises laying out his vision for the benefits and risks as AI advances to transform society with what he called "a country of geniuses in a data center." In multiple essays, however, he has acknowledged the challenge of predicting what's to come. "The effects of powerful AI are likely to be even more unpredictable than past technological changes, so all of this is unavoidably going to consist of guesses," he wrote in Machines of Loving Grace, a widely-read essay later reprinted in pocket-size bound copies given out to employees. "But I am aiming for at least educated and useful guesses."

Shares of Samsung Electronics Co. and SK Hynix Inc. climbed more than 4% each, pushing Kospi up as much as 4.9%. AFP

AI trade bounces back as IPO eases funding jitters

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

Anthropic PBC's IPO filing is reviving the AI trade across Asia, offering reassurance on the billions needed to sustain the buildout while highlighting supply bottlenecks that favour the region's chip and equipment makers.

Shares of Samsung Electronics Co. and SK Hynix Inc. climbed more than 4% each, pushing Korea's equity benchmark Kospi up as much as 4.9%. Japan's Nikkei 225 Stock Average rose as much as 2.4%, with Advantest Corp. up more than 9%. Chip stocks were mixed in Taiwan and China.

Claude-developer Anthropic moving a step closer to listing topped a list of news items overnight that helped calm the market's recent worries on AI financing. Other highlights included SpaceX's $40 billion equipment-finance lease and Meta Platforms Inc.'s plan for a $95 billion share sale.

> Concerns have been mounting over continued funding for the global AI buildout amid soaring debt levels

"Anthropic's landmark IPO filing alongside Meta's aggressive capex push has reignited broader risk appetite, pulling capital out of its defensive crouch and firmly restoring chip stocks back to the driver's seat," said Hebe Chen, a market analyst at Vantage Global Prime.

The filing also highlighted where bottlenecks in the AI buildout remain. Anthropic said most of the world's most advanced chip manufacturing is concentrated in Taiwan, primarily at TSMC, while also flagging constraints in the power equipment needed to expand AI infrastructure.

The rally comes ahead of earnings due this week from Samsung and SK Hynix as well as Big Tech spenders Amazon.com Inc. and Alphabet Inc.

The reports will provide further clues on the health of the AI rally, which has struggled to get back on track after a summer selloff.

Concerns have been mounting over continued funding for the global AI buildout amid soaring debt levels. Investors have also questioned whether the profits will be able to justify lofty stock valuations, leading to disappointing market debuts and scrapped equity deals.

In that context, Anthropic's prospectus for what may be the largest-ever stock market listing provided relief. The company detailed the billions of dollars in sales per year that its products can generate as well as the resources it has to pay for the chips and related equipment it needs to produce them.

The filing "provided some reassurance over the industry's ability to sustain its infrastructure investments," said James Ooi, chief market strategist at Tiger Brokers.

Chip stocks are still fighting their way back as the market seeks more certainty. The Kospi is down more than 35% from its June peak, hurt by drops in Samsung and SK Hynix. Foreign investors have sold more than $150 billion worth of stocks in the South Korean index this year, on a net basis.

"The key question is whether this week's results can restore confidence in the durability of AI-related demand," said Jung In Yun, chief executive officer at Fibonacci Asset Management Global.

"For the recovery to last, we need reassuring earnings guidance and sustained foreign buying."

Broadcom CEO intervened to seal $63 billion Anthropic debt deal

Alexander Saeedy,
Anissa Gardizy & Matt Wirz

Hock Tan was running out of patience.

The CEO of chip maker Broadcom had spent nearly two months trying to get banks to commit over $40 billion to the largest artificial-intelligence debt deal ever. It was meant to allow Anthropic to lease specialized chips that Broadcom is developing with Google.

Though Anthropic was the main beneficiary of the deal, the startup needed help from its bigger commercial partners to raise the money. Together, Anthropic and Broadcom were trying to close the deal ahead of Anthropic's filing for its widely anticipated initial public offering.

Broadcom, the supplier of chips to Anthropic, was at the center of the action. Thanks to its sterling credit rating, it had already agreed to provide some financial guarantees to make banks more comfortable with the sizable risk of lending over $40 billion. But over the past few weeks, some of the banks grew increasingly anxious about participating in the deal, known as "Project North Star," people familiar with the matter said.

Given the rise in interest rates and growing difficulties in the markets for artificial intelligence ventures, some banks felt they weren't being compensated enough to take the risk and considered pulling out altogether, the people said.

In the end, Broadcom's CEO held 11th-hour talks with bank executives over the weekend to get them to finalize their commitment to the deal and also agreed to higher interest rates on the loans, the people familiar with the matter said.

Banks also got more comfort around the guarantees from Broadcom that will protect them from losses in case Anthropic defaults on the loans, the people said. The deal, led by Bank of America , Citigroup , and Morgan Stanley , was announced late Monday after Anthropic released its IPO filing. Another chunk of debt, partially financed by Blackstone, brought the total commitments to $63 billion.

Broadcom's role on different sides of the transaction—supplier, guarantor, negotiator—and the CEO's intervention speak to the interlinked nature of the big AI bets transforming the economy and the high stakes for all involved.

The deal, announced on Monday, is the biggest ever to raise money for AI infrastructure REUTERS

Startups like Anthropic and OpenAI have voracious demand for chips to power their AI models, but they can't just buy all of them on their own. Broadcom and other intermediaries are now helping them raise billions of dollars, but even with their support, raising money for artificial intelligence is becoming more difficult.

Banks and other investors want to limit exposure to the industry, which some believe is exhibiting signs of a financial bubble. Higher interest rates are also making it harder to raise capital, giving lenders an upper hand as they can pick and choose which deals to finance.

In the North Star deal, a shell company is borrowing the $63 billion to buy the chips designed by Broadcom and Google, known as tensor processing units. Anthropic's lease payments are used to repay the loans, and Broadcom uses its balance sheet heft to guarantee that lenders will get their money back. Since the borrower is the shell company, Broadcom only assumes risk if Anthropic can't make its payments.

The $63 billion deal is historic in several respects beyond size. Banks and private-credit firms like Blackstone, which regularly compete with each other, came together on the biggest ever financing of artificial intelligence infrastructure. The banks also plan to distribute half of their debt, around $22 billion, to the investment-grade bond market, the deepest pool of capital in the world.

One risk: The banks don't plan to sell any bonds to fund managers until later next year when the chips are delivered, people familiar with the matter said. If interest rates rise sharply in the interim, the banks could have to sell the debt at a loss because they have promised to cap the interest rate of the loans. Some banks may choose to keep the loans rather than selling at a loss, two bankers close to the deal said.

> Hock Tan held 11th-hour talks with bankers over the weekend to finalize their commitment to the deal

On top of that, North Star involves another $18 billion in riskier debt that won't carry a Broadcom guarantee, half of which will be financed by Blackstone. Private-credit firms, insurers and hedge funds have bought similar deals over the past year but intensifying volatility in financial markets related to AI may curb their willingness to take on the risk tied solely to Anthropic.

North Star is the sequel to another Anthropic and Broadcom chip-financing deal called "Big Sky." Apollo financed some of the riskier parts of that deal and still hasn't been able to complete some deals with investors to unload debt, people familiar with the situation said.

"North Star" is part of one of the many arrangements critics have dubbed "circular financing" as AI companies race to build data centers. In Anthropic's IPO prospectus, the company estimated that it will pay more than $125.2 billion to lease Broadcom chips, and Broadcom and Google have respectively committed to provide $42 billion and $20 billion to Anthropic.

One reason it has been hard for arrangers of the deal to persuade other banks to pitch in: Debt markets are getting indigestion from hundreds of billions of dollars of AI-related bonds and loans. Many banks are still trying to unload loans they already committed to, limiting capacity to make new ones, debt fund managers say.

The flood of supply—combined with investors' mounting fears that some AI bets will go bad—have made the loans a tougher sell. Some banks have traded the loans to clients at a loss to free up capital, while others are holding on, limiting their ability to do new deals. The logjam is leaving some banks stuck with loans made to riskier players in the AI ecosystem.

Morgan Stanley has been struggling to place a roughly $300 million bond backed by loans it made to help finance a data center project in Kansas City dubbed "Project Blitz" operated by Lambda, the debt fund managers said. Lambda is a " neocloud " startup, like Coreweave, that uses borrowed money to buy chips and rent their computational power to AI developers.

Morgan Stanley has found few takers for the Project Blitz bonds despite roughly doubling the yield they will pay, the debt fund managers said.

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

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Israelis vote to decide on Netanyahu

Bloomberg
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Israelis voted in their highest numbers for more than half a century in the country's first election since the October 2023 Hamas attack, effectively a referendum on the war-dominated rule of Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu.

Turnout stood at 31.5% as of 12pm on Tuesday, according to the central election committee, the highest level at this stage in the process since 1973—a highly charged election that followed the Yom Kippur war with Egypt and Syria. Voting will stop at 10pm, when the first exit polls will be published.

Netanyahu, 77, is seeking reelection, saying the military campaigns he's led in Gaza, Lebanon, Syria and against Iran over the past three years have made the country safer. He's been endorsed by US President Donald Trump, who backed him to help "finish the job" in the ongoing war against the Islamic Republic.

Netanyahu's opponents, led by 66-year-old former armed forces chief Gadi Eisenkot, say Israel's longest serving leader is also the nation's greatest threat—and the main reason for its growing international isolation. They point to his bribery indictment—an allegation Netanyahu denies—and partnership with nationalist extremists like Itamar Ben Gvir, who influenced the government's anti-Arab rhetoric and policies.

Polls have consistently forecast that neither Netanyahu nor Eisenkot's blocs will secure enough votes to claim the 61-seat parliamentary majority needed to form a government. Complex, weeks-long negotiations and even a possible second election could follow.

Japan's trading platform hit for $50 mn ransom

Hackers have threatened to leak customer data of retail foreign exchange traders

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

Japan's vulnerability to cyber attacks was on full display again Tuesday as hackers threatened to leak customer data of retail foreign exchange traders and to conduct a ransomware attack unless they were paid $50 million.

With dozens of businesses in the nation reporting breaches to their systems and potential leaks of client data in recent weeks, finance minister Satsuki Katayama said the nation would address the damage from the latest attack with a sense of urgency.

Katayama said there was "a sense of crisis shared globally" over cybersecurity as hackers harness artificial intelligence (AI) to take advantage of vulnerabilities. "Given how rapidly these incidents and circumstances evolve, we will continue to call on financial authorities to respond appropriately and swiftly as developments unfold," she told reporters.

GMO Internet Group, the subject of the latest attack, said it would not agree to the demand from the hackers, which included payment of ¥8 billion ($50 million). It asked customers to scan their PCs for viruses, back up files and unplug and turn off their devices before deadline of noon Tuesday set by the hackers. Hackers targeting GMO Internet Group claim to have published personal information on one GMO customer, *NHK* reported without attribution.

Katayama said earlier that five foreign exchange firms reported customers affected by the GMO incident. She said she received no reports of new unauthorized transactions. GMO sought government assistance on Saturday to help disrupt the source of the attacks.

Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi instructed her cabinet on Monday to draw up emergency measures by the end of next week in response to a wave of cyberattacks targeting Japanese firms.

Finance minister Satsuki Katayama said Japan would address the damage from the latest attack with a sense of urgency. REUTERS

Marito Ueda, president of SBI FX Trade, said the retail currency trading industry as a whole has recently been seeing customers closing dormant accounts, and that with interest rates rising, he expected some people to opt to put money back into bank deposits.

"Yet, those who were actively trading FX appear to have stayed in the market, as trading volumes have not declined," he said. "If the fallout extends beyond FX and into equities for instance, it could become much harder to contain."

Katayama said there was 'a sense of crisis shared globally' over cybersecurity with hackers harnessing AI

At a press conference on Tuesday, economy minister Ryosei Akazawa said the government would offer smaller companies free consultation services on boosting their cybersecurity.

Cyberattacks and the discovery of vulnerabilities in PHP programming language used in some websites have made a swift response an urgent priority for businesses and the government. Several political parties called for stronger measures last week.

In recommendations submitted to Takaichi on 23 October, the ruling Liberal Democratic Party said the recent wave of cyberattacks constituted a serious crisis that could be described as "the eve of a cyber emergency," threatening Japan's national security. It warned that "AI cyber saturation attacks," in which artificial intelligence automatically identifies system vulnerabilities and launches attacks simultaneously, could occur in the near future.

The party also proposed creating a response headquarters led by the prime minister's office, while accelerating efforts to improve the capabilities of the Self-Defense Forces and police and strengthen cooperation with allies. In the financial sector, it called for the public and private sectors to work together to steadily implement defensive measures.

Masaaki Taira, a former digital minister who led the drafting of the recommendations, said attackers are using AI to mount attacks faster and on a broader scale than before, while companies are still relying on people to defend themselves. "Structurally, it has become AI versus humans," he said. The government needs to work with leading AI companies to build a system capable of using AI for defence, he added.

One concern common is securing specialist personnel. With highly skilled private-sector cybersecurity professionals like white-hat hackers in mind, LDP called for the creation of a new personnel and compensation system that can "break through the rigidities of the civil-service system and enable compensation commensurate with market value."

Behind these proposals is a recognition that government salaries are insufficient compared with those in the private sector.

According to the National Personnel Authority, the government can offer annual compensation of as much as ¥33.8 million under its fixed-term appointment system to private-sector personnel with specialized expertise. The latest data show 490 people are employed under the system, but none is receiving compensation at the highest level on a monthly-pay basis.

"Annual compensation of ¥33.8 million is by no means low, but there are limits to how far that level of pay can attract people who are already highly valued in the private sector," said Sumio Morita, senior managing director at human-resources consultancy Towers Watson.

Iran reiterates its conditions for ending war with US

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian. AFP

Iran's Supreme Leader reiterated his country's conditions for ending the war with the US, amid a regional diplomatic push to avert a fresh round of fighting in the Persian Gulf.

Mojtaba Khamenei emphasized the need to implement "the conditions set out by the country's officials, with the aim of ending the war and the 'neither war nor peace' situation" in a meeting with national security chief Mohsen Rezaee, according to a Telegram statement.

Iran has previously said the US must end a naval blockade of its ports on the Persian Gulf and lift sanctions as preconditions of peace talks, while Washington is pushing for Iran to make concessions on its nuclear program.

Khamenei's statement comes amid a flurry of diplomatic activity aimed at preventing another round of US-Israeli strikes on the Islamic Republic and resolving the mounting conflict in Yemen between Saudi Arabia and Iran-backed Houthi rebels.

The statement comes amid a regional diplomatic push to avert a fresh round of fighting in the Gulf

Since Sunday, Tehran has hosted a delegation from Qatar – a key mediator with the US – and top security officials from Saudi Arabia, Turkey and Pakistan. On Tuesday, China's Foreign Ministry said it's also dispatching special envoys to the region "to prevent worsening of the situation."

Meanwhile, Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian has been meeting various senior officials and leaders at a gas summit in Moscow, including Qatar's Emir Sheikh Tamim bin Hamad Al Thani. Pezeshkian is also scheduled to meet Russian President Vladimir Putin during his visit, Interfax reported, citing a Kremlin aide.

As well as the war, Khamenei and Rezaee also discussed "protecting national and regional security through the exercise of control over the Strait of Hormuz," Tuesday's Telegram statement said.

Disagreements over the strait led to the collapse of the last ceasefire between Iran and the US in June. Tehran insists that it retain control over the waterway, which is vital for energy supplies, while the US wants to restore freedom of passage.

The countries are also at odds over Iran's nuclear programme and whether the Islamic Republic should be able to enrich uranium.

Khamenei is Iran's ultimate decision-maker but hasn't appeared in public since the start of the war, sparking speculation about his health and the extent of his control over policy.

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NEWS IN NUMBERS

$20 mn
NEPAL'S ALLOCATION from the UN's climate loss and damage fund after severe August floods amounts to less than 1% of estimated reconstruction costs.

₹2,500 cr
THE AMOUNT luxury brand Jacob & Co and GB Realty plan to invest in a premium Mohali housing project, marking Jacob & Co's entry into Punjab's real estate market.

35
THE NUMBER of balls Abhishek Sharma took to score a century against New Zealand, recording the fastest by an Indian against the Kiwis in T20Is.

₹549 cr
THE RISE in net profit reported by SBI Life Insurance on Tuesday, for the second quarter ended 30 September in the current fiscal.

₹69 cr
THE RISE in consolidated net profit reported by Allied Blenders and Distillers on Tuesday, in the September quarter of FY27.

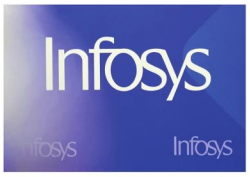
HOWINDIALIVES.COM

India warns of fake Defitelio medicine

India has issued an urgent regulatory alert and mobilized drug inspectors nationwide after the World Health Organization (WHO) warned that a counterfeit batch of Defitelio (defibrotide), an intravenous drug used to treat severe hepatic veno-occlusive disease (VOD) following haematopoietic stem-cell transplantation, is circulating illegally in domestic supply chains.

The alert flags cartons labelled DEFITELIO (defibrotide) 80 mg/mL concentrate for solution for infusion, bearing batch number 24GC01A and an expiry date of April 2027.

The packaging falsely identifies Patheon's facility in Ferentino, Italy, as the manufacturer and Gentium S.r.l., a subsidiary of Jazz Pharmaceuticals, as the marketing authorization holder. The document quoted a German rapid alert as saying: "It should be noted that Defitelio does not have marketing authorization in India." **PRIYANKA SHARMA**



Revenue will rise 1% to 2% on a constant-currency basis in the year through March 2027. REUTERS

Infosys gets four downgrades

Infosys Ltd was downgraded by at least four analysts in a single day after India's second-largest software exporter cut its annual sales forecast, deepening concerns over disruption from artificial intelligence.

Axis Capital Ltd, Arihant Capital Markets Ltd, and IIFL Capital Services Ltd were among brokerages that lowered their ratings on Monday, data compiled by *Bloomberg* show. Three others reduced their recommendations over the weekend, pushing its consensus rating to 3.7 out of 5, the lowest since January 2024.

The downgrades for the sector's bellwether threatens to derail a nascent recovery in India's battered technology shares. The Nifty IT Index is on track for its best month since July, even as concerns mount over soaring debt levels being used to fund the global AI buildout.

Infosys cutting its annual sales forecast signals that a broad-based recovery in IT budgets has yet to materialize. Revenue will rise 1% to 2% on a constant-currency basis in the year through March 2027, the company said late Friday, versus analysts' estimates of just over 2%. **BLOOMBERG**

India's air passenger traffic falls 6.5% in September

Domestic airlines carried 11.82 million passengers in September, as per DGCA data

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MINT

India's domestic air passenger traffic fell 6.5% in September, the steepest year-on-year decline since the pandemic, as higher fares and rising fuel costs compounded seasonal weakness in a market that had been among the world's fastest-growing. The drop was also the sharpest so far in the current fiscal year, extending a slowdown that has persisted through the first nine months of 2026.

Domestic airlines carried 11.82 million passengers in September, down from 12.64 million a year earlier, according to data released by the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA). Traffic also fell 2.5% from 12.13 million in August.

September is traditionally a lean period for Indian aviation, with the monsoon and the end of summer holidays weighing on travel demand. Passenger numbers typically pick up in October as the festive season begins. But higher ticket prices and fuel surcharges have added to the pressure. The weakness extended beyond passenger numbers. Revenue passenger kilometres (RPKs), which measure the distance travelled by paying passengers, fell 7% year-on-year in September, according to a 26 October research note by Equirus Securities.

Airlines also reduced capacity as demand weakened. Domestic flight departures fell to 83,300 in September from 90,600 a year earlier and 87,300 in August, according to the brokerage's report. Available seat kilometres (ASKs), a measure of capacity, declined 7% year-on-year, while flight departures fell 8%.

"Domestic passenger traffic declined 6% YoY to 11.8mn in September 2026, while RPKs fell 7% YoY, reflecting continued demand weakness amid higher airfares," the brokerage said in its report.

Domestic airlines carried 122.35 million passengers between January and September 2026, down 0.82% from 123.37 million in the corresponding period last year, DGCA data showed.

Costs have added to the strain. In Delhi, aviation turbine fuel prices rose from about ₹110 a litre in July to ₹137 on 1 October, up nearly 25% in three months. Fuel accounts for 30-40% of airline operating expenses.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

India seeks bigger share of diesel exports

India's diesel exports are set to surge from 2027, giving the South Asian nation a bigger role in global markets, as state-run companies boost refining capacity, industry officials said on Tuesday.

That will bolster India's position as a swing supplier of refined products in an already tight global market buffeted by the US-Iran and Ukraine-Russia wars that have disrupted trade flows and boosted freight rates worldwide.

"We will be in a happy situation of not only refining for ourselves but for the world," said oil minister Hardeep Singh Puri.

India is becoming a global refining hub as it prepares to boost refining capacity to 300 million tonnes per year by 2030, and increasing further to 400 million tonnes per year later.

In 2027, Indian state refiners will together increase their diesel production capacity by 16.5 million tonnes as they boost capacity of existing refineries, officials said. **REUTERS**

Rupee rises 8 paise against dollar amid elevated crude

The rupee appreciated 8 paise to close at 95.07 against the US dollar on Tuesday, supported by likely intervention from the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) amid elevated crude oil prices and a stronger greenback ahead of the US Federal Reserve's policy decision.

The local currency showed some recovery after RBI interventions but failed to withstand pressure from unabated selling by foreign equity investors, according to forex traders.

In the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 95.17 and traded in a tight range of 95.02 to 95.24 before closing at 95.07 against the greenback, up 8 paise from its previous close.

On Monday, the rupee depreciated for the third consecutive day and settled 22 paise lower at 95.15 against the US dollar.

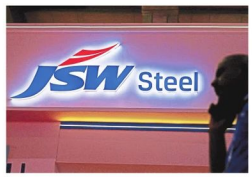
Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, was trading lower by 0.07% but hovered near its six-month high level at $115.73 per barrel in futures trade. **PTI**

Intel to buy Classiq for about $2.3 bn

Intel Corp. agreed to buy Israeli startup Classiq Technologies Ltd as part of a push to capitalize on quantum computing, a still-nascent field that is seeking commercial applications.

The chipmaker will pay about $2.3 billion for Classiq, according to people familiar with the matter who asked not to be identified because the information is private. Intel announced the deal ahead of its third-quarter earnings report Thursday, but didn't disclose a price.

Intel, once the world's largest chipmaker, wants to ensure that it doesn't miss out on quantum technology, a potentially large new market for the semiconductor industry. Chief executive officer Lip-Bu Tan is seeking to regain ground lost to rivals in artificial intelligence computing. Quantum computing relies on the manipulation of subatomic particles to speed up data crunching. **BLOOMBERG**



JSW Steel is developing coking coal mines internationally. REUTERS

'JSW Steel expects 8-9% gain in H2'

JSW Steel Ltd expects second-half volumes to be 8% to 9% higher than the first six months, with price increases taken in September and October helping to offset higher costs.

The Indian steel producer also expects margin pressure to ease with efficiencies including larger blast furnaces, better raw material mix and cost management, chief executive officer Jayant Acharya said.

"Costs have gone up," he said in a *Bloomberg* TV interview, "but we should be able to offset this with prices and efficiencies."

To secure raw-material supply, JSW Steel is developing coking coal mines internationally, including a 30% stake in an Australian operation, as well as construction activity under way in Mozambique that is expected to yield about 11 million tons of hard coking coal, Acharya said. **BLOOMBERG**

Cipla misses Q2 profit estimates

Cipla missed second-quarter profit estimates on Tuesday as a sharp slowdown in its US business eclipsed strong growth at home.

The country's third-largest drugmaker by revenue is experiencing weakness in North America, its biggest overseas market, since the start of the year as sales of generic Revlimid, Bristol Myers Squibb's blood cancer drug, continue to moderate after it went off patent.

Cipla relies on obesity drug Yurpeak, marketed in India under a licensing agreement with Eli Lilly, to support growth.

Yurpeak has been doing well, and Indian revenue growth is likely to track the broader domestic pharmaceutical market, said Shrikant Akolkar, pharma analyst at Nuvama Institutional Equities.

Revenue from the India business rose 12%, while North America revenue fell 19%. **REUTERS**

Coal India's capex rises to ₹7,966 cr

State-owned coal producer Coal India Ltd's (CIL) on Tuesday said its capital expenditure rose 27% to ₹7,966 crore during the first half (H1) of the current financial year from ₹6,283 crore a year ago.

The increased capex comes in the wake of the company's efforts to modernise its mines, expand production capacity and strengthen coal evacuation infrastructure to meet the country's growing energy requirements.

The expenditure also surpassed the H1 target of ₹7,286 crore, achieving 109% of the planned outlay for the period and over 48% of the annual capex target of ₹16,500 crore.

The higher capex reflects CIL sustained focus on bolstering mining infrastructure, land acquisition, procurement of heavy earth moving machinery (HEMM) and progress on diversification projects. Mine infrastructure development emerged as the largest area of investment during the first half of the current fiscal year with ₹2,152 crore. **PTI**

Venu Srinivasan, son, wife and daughter file caveats

FROM PAGE 1

his sister.

The caveats ensure that the court hears a party before passing any order over a petition moved by the rival party. In the TVS family dispute, the father and son are ranged on one side, and the mother and daughter on the other.

The caveats were filed three days after *Mint* reported on 9 October that Mallika and Lakshmi were seeking "a fair settlement" over the assets of the TVS Group, as patriarch Venu Srinivasan was reported to have given much of the ownership to son Sudarshan Venu.

"Is this (filing a caveat) a precursor to this ownership dispute going to court? One cannot say for sure," said an executive who works with Mallika Srinivasan. "Every effort is being made to resolve this amicably. But both sides need to be open to settling," said the executive, declining to elaborate.

Emails sent to Venu Srinivasan and Mallika Srinivasan went unanswered.

"As stated earlier in their joint statement, Dr Lakshmi Venu and Mallika Srinivasan reiterate their desire for an amicable resolution through transparent discussions and dialogue," a spokesperson for the two said.

The 2024 family deal is now facing a challenge. ISTOCKPHOTO

The wider TVS business was divided between Venu Srinivasan and his cousins in 2020. Four years later, Venu Srinivasan and his family members signed another family agreement, under which Venu Srinivasan and Sudarshan control TVS Holdings. They also control the privately owned financial services and real estate business. Srinivasan and Lakshmi control Sundaram-Clayton Ltd, the listed die-casting company. Venu Srinivasan wields control over TVS Motor and Sundaram-Clayton.

Mallika Srinivasan has said the 2024 family agreement was only about managing the businesses, non-compete clauses and using the brand, and did not split ownership of the businesses.

"No economic settlement has taken place within the Venu Srinivasan family," Mallika, chairperson and managing director of Tractors and Farm Equipment Ltd (TAFE), told *Mint* on 13 October, in her first on-record telephone interview on the dispute. "I do believe that the legitimate economic interests of both children must be recognized fairly and equitably," she said.

TVS family members own 59.09% of Sundaram-Clayton. VS Trust, with Venu Srinivasan as sole trustee, owns 46.83%, while a family branch owns 6.87% through TSF Investments Ltd. Srinivasan holds 4.38% personally, and Mallika and Lakshmi own 0.26% and 0.75%.

TVS Holdings owns 56% of TVS Motor. The family holds 74.45% of TVS Holdings: VS Trust owns 66.55%, Srinivasan Trust (with VS Trustee Private Ltd as trustee) owns 3.07%, and the family branch owns 3.74% through TSF Investments. Mallika and Lakshmi own 0.29% and 0.82%.

As the sole trustee of VS Trust, Srinivasan controls voting power in both companies. Lakshmi may run Sundaram-Clayton, but her direct shareholding is less than 1%.

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From brand deals to own brands: creators bet on their audiences

FROM PAGE 1

they connect with and what they respond to. The alignment between their content and the product category matters because it gives people a reason to believe in their brand. But I don't think a creator necessarily has to stay within their niche," said Sudeep Subash, partner and chief revenue officer at talent-management firm Collective Artists Network.

Cohort Studio, a clothing label launched in Ahmedabad in 2024 by lifestyle and fashion creator Vidhisha Patel and fashion creator Dhruvi Godhani, generates 80% of its sales through offline channels, with social media accounting for the remaining 20%. The founders started the business with an initial investment of ₹1 lakh and reported steady growth since launch, but did not disclose financial figures.

"One of the biggest challenges is managing production, inventory and marketing while trying to build a brand that stands out in a crowded market. Fashion involves a lot of planning, from sourcing fabrics and developing designs to organising shoots and launching collections," Patel said.

The move into consumer businesses comes as creators continue to navigate uncertainty around earnings from brand partnerships. Siddarth Singhal, head of talent at Creators@Collective, the creator representation arm of Collective Artists Network, previously told *Mint* that nano creators, who typically have 1,000-10,000 followers, can earn ₹10,000-15,000 per campaign, while micro creators, with 10,000-100,000 followers, can earn ₹25,000-50,000 or more.

Creators want to capitalize on their relationships with followers. MINT

"Smaller creators have an advantage: they understand their niche communities more closely," said Tarun Bansal, founder of influencer marketing firm Viral Fuel Studios. "Instead of investing heavily in a flashy launch, they should start with one strong product, build genuine customer trust and focus on retention rather than just views. Influence can bring customers through the door, but only a good product can make them return."

To be sure, a large following is no guarantee of a lasting business. Actor Deepika Padukone's skincare brand 82°E and cricketer Virat Kohli's fashion label WROGN, both present across social media, quick commerce and offline retail, have faced financial pressure. 82°E's revenue fell 30% to ₹14.7 crore in FY25, with losses of ₹12.26 crore, while WROGN's losses widened 32% to ₹75 crore, *Mint* reported on 1 May 2026. *Mint* also reported on 27 March 2025 that Shahid Kapoor's label Skult and Anushka Sharma's clothing brand Nush were struggling.

Launching a consumer brand is more capital-intensive for creators than offering services such as courses or consulting. "Consumer brands require working capital for product development, inventory, packaging, marketing, fulfilment and returns," said Shweta Kaushal, founder and director of influencer-marketing and talent-management agency CreatorCult. Distribution costs and rising customer-acquisition expenses add to the challenge as brands expand beyond their founders' audiences, she added.

Testing demand before launch can help creators avoid committing capital to products that may not find enough buyers. Raj Mishra, managing director and chief executive of influencer-marketing firm Chtrbox, said creators should establish a clear product proposition and validate demand before investing in a launch.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Reels, drones and wedding Fomo: the price tag on 'I do'

The quest for Instagram-worthy weddings is adding to the bill. Here's how to splurge smart

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Earlier, a slideshow told guests how a couple met or traced their love story. Now, 200 drones might light up the night sky to map it out, while a dedicated social media crew uploads Instagram reels in real time. Paint-and-sip stations, custom photo booths and curated guest activities are also finding a place at weddings.

In the past 2-3 years, the budgets of a big fat Indian wedding have expanded beyond venues, catering, décor and photography to include reel creators, drone shows, mixologists and interactive experiences. As these extras push up costs, couples are turning to do-it-yourself (DIY) ideas and financial planning to stay within budget.

Reels, drone show and memories

"Weddings have changed quite a bit. Earlier, the spending was around the venue, food, décor, and photography," Pradeep Chandar, creative director at Chennai-based Marriage Colours, said. "Now, couples are looking at a lot more, like content creators for instant reels, personalized guest experiences, welcome hampers, live entertainment, hospitality teams, and even separate budgets for pre-wedding celebrations."

Sahil Rathod, co-founder, Shubhtithi Weddings, said dedicated social media vendors have become a distinct expense. "Earlier, photographers used to edit the reels, but now there are dedicated vendors for social media content shooting reels, posting live stories and tagging everyone. High-end teams charge ₹3-4 lakh for two days, but most couples are comfortable spending ₹1-1.5 lakh for 10-15 reels and live stories."

Drone shows and interactive stalls add to the bill. Chandar said some operators charge ₹6-10 lakh, while shows featuring 150-200 drones can cost ₹20 lakh. Digital projection mapping and LED installations are also replacing physical décor. Rathod said game stalls cost ₹8,000 for simple setups and up to ₹50,000 for elaborate ones.

Post-wedding dinners, mixologists and hospitality managers add to costs, said Santosh Joseph, founder of Germinate Investment Services. "When it comes to offering curated experiences, you end up paying for more people, managers, and specialized vendors."

Chandar said such experiences can raise metro wedding budgets by up to 20%, adding ₹2 lakh to ₹20 lakh.

DIY savings

Some couples are cutting costs by doing more themselves. Teresa Chappala, 30, a specialist in air cargo imports from Mumbai, and her fiancé handled much of the creative work for a simple Christian wedding. "By dedicating our time and design skills, we managed to by- pass heavy vendor premiums and cut down costs drastically without sacrificing the elegance of our wedding."

They made mirror prints for welcome boards, designed wedding brochures, made the bridal bouquet, built a photo booth, and skipped professional pre-wedding photography. "We did our entire pre-wedding shoot on a smartphone. The quality of mobile cameras nowadays is incredible, and the resulting photos feel far more authentic and intimate to us," she said.

They designed their car décor and enlisted friends to help with venue logistics. "To use low-cost alternatives, you need to be ready to invest your own time. The small changes we made ended up making our wedding even more personal," Chappala added.

Their décor cost ₹20,000, against vendor quotes of ₹50,000. Venue and catering costs were unchanged.

Cutting the extras

For others, the challenge is separating personal priorities from social pressure. Pratap Khandulwan, 26, a cybersecurity professional from Navi Mumbai, planned a temple wedding with 25-30 relatives. Accommodating his parents' wishes pushed the estimated budget up by more than 80%. He and his fiancée then identified the priorities. "Initially we considered cinematic videos and drone shots, but realized we didn't really need them. Just because something is trending on social media doesn't mean it has to be part of our wedding," he said.

Experts say couples should prioritize long-term financial goals before splurging on the big day

They prioritised traditional rituals, pooja and quality food, while cutting trendy extras, opting for standard photography without videography, dropping pre-wedding shoots, bundling catering and décor, and negotiating with venues. "Our biggest learning is that a wedding budget doesn't increase only because of luxury; sometimes it grows due to many seemingly small additions," said Khandulwan. The couple also cut discretionary spending and outings. "We want to travel, enjoy our married life, and create experiences beyond a single celebration rather than spending for social expectations."

"For the cost-conscious, research and knowing market value can go a long way," Rathod said. Most couples have switched to digital invitations; flexible dates can also save money, he added. "Couples flexible on dates can secure venues at low rates or with major discounts during off-season."

Couples can also save on décor without sacrificing visual appeal. "Instead of spending heavily on elaborate physical backdrops, couples choose one well-designed stage with digital visuals that change through the evening," Chandar noted.

Emergency buffers and planning

Social media has widened the range of wedding choices, fuelling peer pressure and herd mentality, said Anand Damani, behavioural scientist and founder of Briefcase. "While choice brings freedom, too many options cause decision fatigue and cognitive overload. The variety leads people to indulge." Damani urged couples to recognise and resist social proof.

PeakAlpha Investments co-founder and director Priya Sunder advises clients to assess spending against their net worth and factor in 10-15% inflation. "Our role is to explain consequences and guide the best decision. A wedding expense should only be considered affordable after setting aside money for retirement, primary future goals, and children's education," Sunder stressed. "If your portfolio doesn't support the spend, or if taking a loan becomes necessary, that is an immediate signal to rationalize and scale down."

Joseph recommends starting preparations early to avoid rush premiums. "Last-minute escalations can bump up budgets by up to 20%. It is essential to keep a 15-20% emergency buffer for extras and unknowns."

By resisting social media-driven pressure, protecting long-term goals and maintaining an emergency buffer, couples can celebrate without depleting their savings.

Scan the QR code to read an extended version of this story.

Economics of modern weddings

How couples are navigating rising costs of experiential wedding while finding creative, cost-conscious alternatives.

Couples on cutting costs

TERESA CHAPPALA (30)
Senior specialist, Air cargo imports, Mumbai

"By dedicating our time and design skills, we managed to bypass high vendor premiums and cut costs."

PRATAP KHANDULWAN (26)
Cybersecurity professional, Navi Mumbai

"Just because something is trending on social media doesn't mean it has to be part of our wedding."

Planner perspectives on trends

PRADEEP CHANDAR
Creative director, Marriage Colours, Chennai

"Couples are looking at content creators, experiences and separate pre-wedding budgets, which can push up costs by 20%."

SAHIL RATHOD
Co-founder, Shubhtithi Weddings, Mumbai

"There are dedicated vendors for social media content creation who shoot reels and post live stories."

Wedding economics and alternatives

Content creator fee:	Drone light shows:	Interactive stalls:	Budget impact:	Cost-saving hacks:
Around ₹1 lakh to ₹1.5 lakh for 10-15 reels and live coverage	Around ₹6 lakh to ₹20 lakh depending on scale	Around ₹8,000 for simple setups to ₹50,000 for elaborate games	Innovative additions can push metro wedding budgets up by up to 20%.	Digital invitations, smartphone pre-wedding shoots, DIY décor and off-season dates.

Source: Marriage Colours, Shubhtithi Weddings

Financial advisory and planning tips

- **Resist social proof:** Avoid social pressure and avoid overspending triggered by social media.
- **Net worth:** Fund weddings only after securing retirement savings, children's education funds and other financial goals.
- **Avoid debt:** Scale down the wedding if funding it requires taking a personal loan.
- **Emergency buffer:** Maintain a 15-20% contingency buffer for last-minute cost escalation.

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GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

Can a video recording protect your will from future disputes?

Rohit Jain & Keshav Singhania

ASK MINT
ESTATE PLAN

If I videograph the execution of my will, can it meaningfully strengthen the evidentiary record, and how to record the proceedings?
—Name withheld on request

Videographing a will's execution can strengthen the evidentiary record by showing that the testator understood the document, was mentally capable, acted voluntarily and signed it in the presence of witnesses. Indian courts have recognised such recordings as relevant supporting evidence when assessing a will's genuineness and the circumstances of its execution. However, a video cannot replace proper execution, attesting witnesses or legal formalities. Its value lies in preserving the circumstances of execution for scrutiny after the testator is no longer available to explain them. That value, however, depends heavily on how the recording is made. To serve its purpose, a well-made recording must be clear and credible.

The testator must be clearly identifiable and confirm that he understands the document, its effect and that it reflects his wish. The will must be visible on camera, with the recording establishing that it is the same document being signed and attested. Attesting witnesses and others present should also be identifiable. The footage must establish what was executed, by whom and under what circumstances. The recording should also demonstrate that the Will was executed voluntarily, free from undue influence or excessive involvement by anyone who stands to benefit from it.

Continuity does matter. A single, uninterrupted recording is generally preferable to multiple takes or edited clips, which may raise questions about what occurred off camera. An overly staged or poorly executed recording can create as many doubts as it seeks to dispel. The original file should be preserved securely, along with its metadata and date and time information. Where possible, a reliable audit trail should also be maintained to record any subsequent access to or alteration of the file.

To be sure, videography can often strengthen the evidentiary record, but it does not make a will immune from challenge or constitute conclusive proof of its validity. The recording itself may be questioned on grounds of editing, manipulation or, increasingly, AI-generated alteration. As deepfake technology becomes more sophisticated, preserving the original file, witness testimony and other traditional supporting evidence becomes all the more important. The camera does not prove the will. It preserves the moment that may later need to be proved.

Rohit Jain is managing partner, and Keshav Singhania is the head of private client at Singhania & Co.

Do you have a personal finance query? Send in your queries at **mintmoney@livemint.com** and get them answered by industry experts.

Compare bank FD rates

Bank fixed deposits (FDs) continue to be popular investment products not just among senior citizens, who are looking for guaranteed income, but also among investors who can't stomach risk. But overexposure to FDs is not good, and you need to assess your asset allocation and goals to decide how much money you should park in them. For instance, saving for your child's higher education that's 15 years away through FDs may not be effective as the post-tax interest rate of an FD may not give you a real return (return that's above the rate of inflation). But if you plan to take a holiday in two years, an FD can help. Before choosing an FD, you should compare the interest rates on offer. Here is a list of banks that offer the highest FD rates for deposits up to ₹1 crore over various tenures.

Interest rates (%) for fixed deposits up to ₹1 crore

	6 months to <1 year	1 to <2 years	2 to <3 years	3 to <5 years	5 years and above
DCB Bank	6.00-6.50	**6.90-7.10**	6.90-7.50	**7.00-7.10**	7.00-7.50
Jammu & Kashmir Bank	5.50-6.00	**6.55-6.65**	6.70-6.75	**6.70**	6.75
YES Bank	4.75-6.50	**6.65-7.25**	6.90-7.00	**7.00**	6.75
RBL Bank	4.75-6.05	**6.90-7.00**	7.00	**7.00**	6.70
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	6.30-6.50	**6.60-7.25**	7.00	**6.70**	6.70
ICICI Bank	4.50-5.50	**6.25-6.30**	6.30-6.55	**6.55-6.60**	6.60
IndusInd Bank	5.75-6.25	**6.75-6.90**	7.00	**6.65-7.00**	6.50-6.65
Dhanlaxmi Bank	5.50	**6.25-7.10**	6.25-6.50	**6.50-7.25**	6.50-6.60
Axis Bank	5.50-5.75	**6.25-6.50**	6.50	**6.50**	6.50
Federal Bank	4.50-6.00	**6.25-6.65**	6.50-6.55	**6.40-6.70**	6.40
City Union Bank	5.75-6.25	**6.65-7.30**	7.30	**6.55-7.30**	6.25-6.55
Karur Vysya Bank	6.00-7.00	**6.55-7.20**	6.55	**6.55**	6.25-6.55
Kotak Mahindra Bank	5.00-6.00	**6.35-6.55**	6.65	**6.40**	6.25
Canara Bank	5.25-5.50	**6.25-6.60**	6.25	**6.25**	6.25
HDFC Bank	4.25-5.75	**6.25-6.45**	6.45	**6.40-6.50**	6.15-6.40
Indian Overseas Bank	4.50-5.50	**6.40-6.60**	6.40	**6.10**	6.10

Data taken from respective bank's website as on 26 October 2026; Only main entity of the merged banks are taken. Banks which merged with its main entity are removed from the table; The list of 16 banks is based on highest fixed deposit rates available for 5 years and above.

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Source: www.Bankbazaar.com

HOW MUCH WILL MY HOSPITAL STAY COST? FAMILIES DESERVE CLARITY IN MINUTES

POWER POINT
DR AJAY BAKSHI

We welcome your views and comments at **mintmoney@livemint.com**

On 12 October, the Union health ministry asked every state to make hospitals display their prices. It is a welcome step, but not enough. A hospital's rate card can list 2,000 prices, and a family in a crisis cannot make head or tail of it—nor does a list tell them what their final bill will be.

As a clinician and former hospital chief executive, I have seen why. Hospitals treat a wide range of ailments with advanced technologies and a wide variety of medications, so a single bill can run into hundreds of line items. And all the labour, materials and equipment used must be captured and fed to the billing system in real time—without errors. Families expect (almost demand) a narrow estimate. But each patient is unique, and even for common procedures, complications can and do happen.

Many hospitals solve this with packages—a hernia surgery package, for example, covering the room, the surgery, the medicines and some specific tests. But a diabetic patient needs more tests, a patient with heart failure needs care from the cardiology team, and an unexpected complication (an allergy to a medicine, say) lengthens the stay. Off-the-shelf packages cannot capture every scenario, and families perceive any variation from the estimate as dishonesty.

Transparency is key

Transparency generates trust, but only transparency that a family can use. A family should be able to take a recommendation from a trusted doctor and get price quotes for exactly that treatment from 10 hospitals—within minutes, and all online. That needs two steps.

First, a treatment recommendation from their doctor in four standardized parts: the treatment (medical or surgical), the expected length of stay, any high-value implants or devices, and the patient's known conditions (diabetes or heart failure, for example). The hospital's software, not the doctor, would code the treatment in the Central Government Health Scheme (CGHS) code list of October 2025, which covers about 2,000 services—the vast majority of what tertiary care hospitals do.

CGHS would serve as a common language and a base coding system, not a price cap. The recommendation would belong to the patient in their digital health record.

Second, each hospital publishes its own price in rupees for each of these codes (by room category where it applies), in a format that apps can read, and keeps it current. How a hospital sets those prices remains its own business. A family will rarely read this list. Their app will.

Medicines and consumables are harder. Hospitals bill them at the printed maximum retail price (MRP), and the amounts they pay their suppliers are commercially confidential. Rather than reveal their margins, hospitals should publish what their prices exclude, the MRP of high-value implants and devices, and an indicative range of what medicines and consumables have typically added to the bill for each code. A planned hernia repair can be estimated closely. A patient admitted with heart failure can only be given a range because no doctor can predict on day one how long that patient will need intensive care.

The same two steps work for insured patients. The rates hospitals negotiate with insurers are confidential and need not be published. An insured family can upload its coded recommendation into the insurer's app. And the insurer, which already holds those rates, can show its policyholder the likely co-payment, room-rent eligibility and use of the sum insured at each network hospital—without revealing the rates to anyone else.

With these inputs, third-party apps and insurers can turn a treatment recommendation into a rupee estimate for every hospital, and a new ecosystem will grow around what doctors and hospitals publish. If a doctor at a second hospital changes the plan, that hospital must explain the reason in writing before admission.

Insurers can generate cost estimates in minutes to help patients weigh their options

It is a win-win. Hospitals retain the freedom to set their own prices, and families (cash or insured) receive comparable estimates within minutes, which they can use to make an informed decision about which hospital to select. Other factors, such as the quality of care, the doctors, customer friendliness and additional facilities, will help hospitals differentiate themselves beyond pricing.

The 12 October letter was a good first step. The next step is for the government to enforce meaningful price transparency and support an independent information ecosystem to help families make informed decisions, without regulating prices.

Ajay Bakshi, neurosurgeon and former CEO of three hospitals.

OUR VIEW

ISTOCKPHOTO

Indian cities desperately need more public spaces

Creating such spaces is a central responsibility of our urban planning not just to improve productivity and liveability but to allow for democratic dissent and thus improve civic life

The recent protests against the Election Commission have brought to the fore an under-studied aspect of urban life in the country: the lack of adequate public spaces. In Delhi, activists have decried the new rule barring protests at Jantar Mantar. In Bengaluru, social activists are up in arms against city and state officials for restricting protests anywhere outside Freedom Park. Traders want protest sites at a safe distance from commercial centres to avoid traffic snarls.

The dispute over protest sites should make us question why our cities have so few places where people can gather without disrupting everyday life. Indian cities have been adding buildings and vehicles without creating adequate streets, squares, parks, playgrounds and waterfronts. Legitimate users of scarce public space compete with each other: pedestrians with vehicles, and protesters with commuters.

In a typical Indian city, less than 20% of urban land constitutes the public realm. A UN-Habitat assessment found that only 30% of Jaipur's residents lived within 500 metres of accessible open space. A 2024 study found that 19 of Bengaluru's 198 wards had no parks, despite its reputation as India's Garden City. Mumbai offers barely 1.24 square metres of accessible open space per person, against India's recommended 10-12 square metres. At India's high urban densities, these shortages undermine both productivity and liveability.

UN-Habitat recommends an indicative allocation of 45% of urban land to public space: 30% for streets and sidewalks, and 15% for other open spaces. Well-functioning cities typically devote a substantial part of their land to the public realm.

Markets cannot adequately supply such public goods—how will they recover their costs? Creating this public realm is a central responsibility of urban planning, and maintaining them is the prime role of urban governance. Every new building increases demand for streets, parks and gathering places, but these cannot be adequately provided plot-by-plot. They require coordinated planning and land assembly. Private development can add floor space far more easily than cities can create public space. Cities must, therefore, secure sufficient public spaces before private development raises the costs of creating such spaces. Otherwise, we risk building denser cities without the public infrastructure needed to make them productive and liveable.

Our cities need both private development and public provisioning. Manhattan generates more than $1 trillion in economic output across just 59 square kilometres. Yet, nearly half its land is devoted to the public realm, including 36% to streets alone. Public space should not be seen as land lost to economic activity. It is part of what makes such activity possible.

The case for public space extends beyond its economic contribution. Its scarcity also narrows the space for democratic dissent. When protests disrupt the daily lives of fellow citizens competing for the same limited space, that may erode the very public sympathy they seek to mobilise. In 2011, Zuccotti Park, a small public square in Manhattan's financial district, became the epicentre of the Occupy Wall Street movement, demonstrating how public spaces can give democratic dissent a visible place in the heart of a thriving commercial district. Expanding the public realm is, therefore, an investment in civic life.

THEIR VIEW

India's steel ambitions require a clear climate transition roadmap

Achievable milestones are needed to make the steel policy's 2047 goal for cleaner output meaningful

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As climate change intensifies and the world shifts towards lower-carbon industries, India wants to nearly triple its steelmaking capacity by 2047 while reducing emissions from production. Steel is absolutely essential to infrastructure and manufacturing but producing more of it, even more efficiently, does not necessarily mean reducing overall emissions. India's draft National Steel Policy Vision 2047 needs to address this tension more directly because decisions made today will shape the industry's carbon footprint for decades.

The scale of the challenge is clear. The draft seeks to raise steelmaking capacity to 604 million tonnes a year by 2047 and reduce emissions intensity from 2.54 tonnes of carbon dioxide per tonne of crude steel to 1.54 tonnes. Yet, if production grows as projected, total emissions could rise even as each tonne becomes cleaner. The government cannot leave this contradiction unresolved until the target year. It needs to measure both emissions per tonne and the industry's total emissions, and make progress towards reducing them visibly well before 2047.

That requires a more practical approach to the different parts of the industry. Big producers like Tata Steel, JSW Steel and Steel Authority of India must improve existing plants while deciding how to build new capacity. Existing facilities need realistic plans to save energy, use cleaner power and reduce coal consumption. New plants present a different opportunity. Cleaner technologies can be built into their design, avoiding the expense of correcting carbon-intensive choices later. The policy should make these distinctions explicit and require companies to show how their investment plans fit the industry's emissions goals.

The challenge is equally pressing for medium-sized and secondary steelmakers, which often lack the financial muscle of large integrated producers. Many use induction furnaces or other smaller-scale processes. They need access to efficient equipment, affordable finance, reliable electricity and better-quality scrap. A policy that sets ambitions without helping these businesses modernize risks leaving a large part of the industry behind. Support should be linked to practical improvements that smaller producers can afford to deliver.

The policy, therefore, needs clear interim milestones, beginning well before 2047. A series of measurable milestones would set a clear direction for emissions reductions, distinguish the responsibilities of existing and new plants, and recognize the different capacities of large, medium-sized, secondary and speciality steelmakers. Regular reviews should reveal whether progress is keeping pace with expansion and where policy support or investment needs to change.

The government has already taken steps towards cleaner production. Its green steel taxonomy provides a framework for identifying steel with lower emissions. The next task is to turn such initiatives into a wider industrial transition. Public procurement can help create demand for cleaner products, while financial and technical support can help producers invest in the equipment and energy systems needed to supply them.

Export competitiveness adds to the case for action. The European Union's carbon tax applies to specified steel products entering its market, making the emissions associated with production relevant to trade costs. Its direct reach across India's steel industry is limited, but the broader need to control energy costs, secure raw materials and demonstrate environmental performance will not disappear.

For a successful industrial transition, the policy has to encourage producers to move up the value chain while reducing the environmental cost of production. More steel is not the only measure of industrial progress. What India can manufacture, and how efficiently it does so, matter just as much. The test of the new policy will not be whether India can reach its 2047 targets on paper, but whether its largest producers, smaller steelmakers and speciality manufacturers can make measurable progress along the way.

All these make the case for clearer interim milestones to turn a distant ambition into a programme of action, and give industry, investors and the government a chance to correct course before today's decisions become tomorrow's liabilities. A vision for 2047 sets the destination. Milestones make it achievable. A target two decades away offers little guidance unless the government spells out what must change, and how soon.

India does not have to choose between producing more steel and tackling climate change. The country needs more steel, but it also needs to avoid locking itself into production systems that become increasingly expensive to change. A credible transition plan would give companies greater clarity, help investors judge risks and make the government's climate ambitions more meaningful.

The success of India's steel policy should not be measured only by how much steel the country can produce by 2047. It should also be measured by whether the industry can get there without leaving a far larger carbon burden for future generations.

10 YEARS AGO

mint

Reasons for rift revealed as Tata replies to Mistry

JUST A THOUGHT

"Cultures and climate differ all over the world, but people are the same. They'll gather in public, if you give them a good place to do it.

JAN GEHL

MY VIEW | EX MACHINA

Human vs AI writing: does it truly matter who writes?

RAHUL MATTHAN

is a partner at Trilegal and his latest book is 'Ex Machina: Essays on a Decade of Tech Policy'. His X handle is @matthan.

Earlier this year, the Supreme Court of Colombia dismissed an appeal after an artificial intelligence (AI) detector called Winston found that the filing contained "only 7% human content," holding that it could not, for this among other reasons, be admitted as a validly submitted pleading. Shortly thereafter, a lawyer, Emmanuel Alessio Velasquez, ran the court's own ruling through the same detector, which suggested that the judgment itself was 93% AI-generated.

X-raying documents for traces of AI seems to be all the rage these days. In September, an anonymous user posted Pangram results suggesting that Thélyson Orélien's novel *C'était ça ou mourir* had been generated by AI. In response, the Goncourt jury took the extreme step of dropping the book from its prestigious longlist. And when a researcher, Linch Zhang, ran *Magnifica Humanitas*—Pope Leo XIV's encyclical on humans in the age of AI—through Pangram, even though virtually the entire document was found to be human-written, the fact that Pangram flagged a handful of paragraphs as AI-generated was enough to shift some of the attention away from what it was saying to who wrote it.

Modern AI has become so good at generating text that, in many instances, it is impossible to tell its work apart from ours, which is why so many have turned to detectors. We have, as a result, become more obsessed with how content was created than with what it actually says. I have always believed that good writing is anything that is worth reading, regardless of how it was written or by whom. The articles I most enjoy are those that make me stop and think, force me to question my beliefs and encourage me to dive into new rabbit holes of discovery. I also like articles with a stylish turn of phrase and literary construction that make me step back and marvel at how they were put together. Every piece of writing that has some (or all) of these elements is, in my view, worth reading.

Almost from the day this column started, readers have asked me about my process. Where do I get my ideas from, how long do I spend on research, and how do I find the time to churn out an article every week for so long? I would be lying if I said that any of this was easy. Figuring out what to write each week—especially in the early days of the column—has always been a nerve-wracking exercise, and there have been weeks where my mind has remained stubbornly blank as the print deadline has drawn inexorably nearer.

Coping with this has meant developing a number of systems and processes over the years. I've kept notebooks to jot down ideas as they come to mind, used personal knowledge management systems to process drafts and a variety of writing apps to generate the final polished product. But nothing has helped me get from the germ of an idea to a published article with as much reliable certainty as my current AI-powered workflow. So much so that it is hard for me to say how much of the past 100 or so articles in this column have come out of my own mind and how much from AI.

Here is how it works. Every column starts from something I read or heard at a conference or a thought that occurred to me in the middle of a podcast. Today, the moment a new idea strikes, I register it in my germination bench—an "idea-store" that AI maintains, where every nascent idea is nurtured and processed until it has enough substance for a full-blown article. When the time comes to write, AI scans the germination bench to find something suitable—a new idea, one that extends what I have said before, or one that addresses an issue I have yet to cover. I then structure what I want to say using AI, working out the main claim of the piece and how it should be presented. We go back and forth on the narrative structure, working out what each paragraph needs to do until we settle on the spine of the piece to my satisfaction.

Modern AI writing is hard to tell apart but it need not be an issue so long as the content holds value

In the next stage, with the outline settled, AI does all the legwork. It researches the arguments, verifies the facts and finds the sources for every claim I intend to rely on. Its work is checked along the way—a separate reviewer questions the plan, and every fact is checked against its source—not just to limit hallucinations but also to make sure that the sources are sound and reputable. It is only then that it begins drafting, ensuring that every sentence it generates adheres as closely as possible to the "voice" of my columns. The draft that comes out of this AI workflow is far closer to something I would have written myself than if I had just asked it to write an article from scratch.

No theme has more consistently run through all my columns than the idea that, rather than resisting the inevitable march of technology, we need to learn to work with it, immersing ourselves deeply in it so we can take advantage of the new possibilities it presents. I have, in my own life, tried to practise what I preach, and as AI has become increasingly capable, I am constantly trying to figure out how to make it as useful to me as possible.

As with many of my recent columns, this, my 500th Ex Machina article, has been written entirely using my AI workflow. If you have read this far, it has passed the only test that matters—holding your attention all the way to the end. Some of you will doubtless run it through an AI detector to see how much of it is flagged as AI. But if you found it interesting, does it really matter whether AI wrote 5% of it or 95%?

GUEST VIEW

We need a holistic approach to tackle the urban heat problem

Indian policy must focus on driving long-term urban resilience to check rising heat in our cities and avoid economic losses

SHIKHA SRIVASTAVA
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ISTOCKPHOTO

India's cities are no longer just experiencing heat; they are also actively generating it. Concrete replaces wetlands, glass towers rise where trees once stood and water-bodies are paved over. Air conditioners cool houses while warming the street outside. Heat is no longer an occasional weather event. It is becoming a defining condition of everyday urban life.

Every year, as temperatures rise across India, cities become increasingly responsive. They issue advisories, create installations for water kiosks and shut schools early. These are necessary, life-saving interventions, but increasingly, they are feeling like treating symptoms of a disease while ignoring the root cause.

There is the reality of the urban heat island effect, making neighbourhoods significantly hotter than surrounding regions. In Mumbai, denser suburbs such as Ghatkopar and Vasai West have recorded average temperatures more than 10 degrees Celsius higher than greener, less densely built areas such as Powai, reflecting strong local heat-island effects.

Bengaluru offers another stark example. Over the past five decades, the city has seen a 1,078% surge in concrete and construction, alongside an 88% decline in vegetation cover and a 79% decline in water cover. This has pushed surface temperatures significantly higher. This is not only climate change; it is also an urban planning limitation.

The burden of this urban heat island phenomenon is falling disproportionately on those least responsible for it.

For many of us, heat is an inconvenience solved with air-conditioned offices and homes. We step indoors, switch on the air conditioner, postpone errands or escape to cooler places. But for informal workers, whether in homes under tin roofs, on the street or at construction sites, heat is a threat to health, income and survival. When temperatures rise, their livelihoods fall. According to *The Lancet*, India lost 247 billion potential labour hours in 2024, with agriculture (66%) and construction (20%) bearing a disproportionate brunt. Households already on the edge of economic crisis absorb the greatest loss. Heatstroke cases have risen sharply in recent years, but the quieter crisis is the erosion of everyday earning and difficult living conditions. The conversation on heat stress must evolve from emergency response to long-term urban resilience.

Heat is an interconnected systems challenge linked to water, housing, waste, green cover, livelihood and governance. The question is not simply how to help people survive hotter days, but how to build cities that are cooler, healthier and more equitable. Cool roofs matter. So do shaded public spaces. But a cool roof without water security, or tree planting without groundwater recharge, cannot solve heat stress in isolation. Heat is deeply tied to disappearing water bodies, shrinking green cover, poor housing design, burning waste and degraded public infrastructure. Integrated thinking must guide robust heat action plans as well as the way cities are planned and governed.

To do this, we must move beyond piecemeal interventions and develop holistic solutions. Increasingly, collaborative efforts supported by the Tata Trusts are bringing together technical expertise, community knowledge and local participation to address heat in a more integrated way—linking housing, water systems, public spaces, green cover and waste management.

In Patan, Gujarat, one of the hotter and more climate-vulnerable districts experiencing both environmental and socioeconomic vulnerability, work is underway with grassroots organizations such as Mahila Housing Trust to combine household-level and community resilience. This includes cool roofs, mist-cooled public spaces, green spaces and rainwater recharge structures in vulnerable neighbourhoods to improve water access. This is not only about restoring water access; it is also about improving the local microclimate, reducing heat vulnerability, strengthening women's leadership in climate adaptation, and rebuilding shared resource stewardship.

Similarly, in Mira Bhayandar in Mumbai and Chandrapur district in Maharashtra, interventions with Aga Khan Agency for Habitat integrate thermal mapping and hydrogeological studies with cool roof solutions, enhanced green cover, water body rejuvenation and groundwater recharge. Local communities are also participating in identifying heat-vulnerable zones and shaping locally relevant responses. Resilience is not only about large-scale policy and infrastructural changes, but also locally adaptive solutions. And no single intervention is enough. This is why building collaborations across civil society organizations is important, bringing together diverse expertise, deep contextual knowledge and the capacity to meaningfully mobilize communities.

The opportunity lies in convergence. A settlement should not have to choose between a cool roof and a functioning water body; it should have both. A city should not retrofit heat resilience after poor planning; it should design for resilience from the start with appropriate building materials, green spaces and built environment designs. This also means communities themselves must move from being beneficiaries to decision-makers.

Traditional Indian architecture understood this better than many modern cities do. Lime plaster, thick walls, internal courtyards, natural ventilation and shaded streets were part of a cohesive design philosophy. They worked with local climate conditions, regulated temperature naturally and embedded comfort in the very structure of everyday life.

If our cities are being built in ways that produce heat, they also have the potential to reduce it. The future of urban resilience will depend on how we design resilience into everyday life.

MINT CURATOR

Election fraud needn't happen for US voters to worry about it

The Trump administration is sowing doubt about midterm results

MARY ELLEN KLAS
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State election officials have locked arms to resist interference. ISTOCKPHOTO

You've likely heard the ominous what-if scenarios about US [mid-term] election disruptions in November: immigration agents or federal troops roaming polling places, federal officials seizing ballots and voting machines, and President Donald Trump issuing an executive order postponing or cancelling the election. Courts and legal experts have given solid reasons that each one of those potential election disruptions is unlikely. But the threats have served their purpose: People are harbouring doubts.

The federal government doesn't have to interfere with the mechanics of the voting process to disrupt the election. The easiest way for bad actors to interfere right now is to let fear and distrust mess with our minds. By intimidating people into thinking they'll face harassment at the polls or casting doubt on the integrity of the process, the administration is planting the seeds that the results can't be trusted.

I recently spoke with a naturalized US citizen from Venezuela who lives in Miami. She's a reliable voter, but she told me she won't be voting in person this year. The Immigration and customs enforcement (ICE) raids that have terrorized her community have left her and her neighbours isolated and afraid.

This is where Trump has brought us: US citizens fear risking their safety to exercise their constitutional right to vote.

For the last 21 months, the federal government has mounted an unprecedented attack on state sovereignty over elections. Trump signed two executive orders that seek to radically dictate state election policy. The department of justice sued 30 states and the District of Columbia to gain access to sensitive voter data. The White House seized Georgia's ballots from the 2020 election. And Trump tried to rehash his election conspiracy theories in a prime-time speech earlier this year.

Judges from county courthouses to the US Supreme Court have rebuffed much of it. But the effort has undercut voter confidence. A University of Georgia survey of more than 11,000 voters found only 58% of Republicans, 63% of Democrats, and 49% of Independents trusted that votes would be counted accurately nationwide. And a recent poll from AP-NORC Center for Public Affairs Research found that only 34% of US adults trust government certifications of election results "a great deal" or "quite a bit," down from 40% in 2024.

Sometimes all it takes is a headline to sow doubt. That's what happened in 2016 when Russian hackers got access to the Illinois state voter registration database. The hackers went unnoticed for weeks and only when they started accessing thousands of records per second did Illinois election officials shut the system down.

"Russia wanted to be noticed," said David Becker, who runs the non-partisan election watchdog site The Center for Election Innovation and Research. "They wanted the American people to think that our foreign adversaries had... the ability to change our elections." Since then, US adversaries, particularly Russia, Iran and China, have focused on manipulating social media to make voters, particularly supporters of losing candidates, believe that their elections were stolen.

Fortunately, millions of voters haven't been intimidated by these global or domestic scare tactics. Records indicate that two weeks into early voting, an unprecedented number of votes have already been cast.

And in unprecedented fashion, state elections officials have locked arms in a bipartisan effort to resist any attempt by the administration to interfere.

State officials are taking a traditional "all hazards approach," said Minnesota secretary of state Steve Simon. They're prepared to handle election disruptions involving everything from natural disasters and bomb threats to power outages. This year, he told me, they've added "federal interference."

States have amassed teams of lawyers who are prepared to act quickly in the unlikely event that federal troops do show up, said Becker. They are also prepared to get before a judge if federal officials attempt to seize election equipment and get a ruling "before the chain of custody is irrevocably damaged," he explained.

But as a reminder, it's a crime for anyone to order federal troops to a polling place—a violation punishable by up to five years in prison, a fine and disqualification from public office. Federal laws bar ICE agents from the polls. And it's logistically impossible for Trump to cancel an election because thousands of officials across the country control elections, not the White House.

The internet is an inviting host for allowing the mischief to continue in the weeks ahead. Let's keep our wits about us. Thank the hard-working elections officials who keep the system sound, and don't be duped. ©BLOOMBERG

GUEST VIEW

Diagnostic firms are using an old marketing playbook

CHANDRAKANT LAHARIYA

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Most of us would have found a newspaper flyer offering a discounted 'full-body' check-up: 100 or more tests at a price too good to ignore. Many of us would have had such a package done at some point in the last few years. The detailed report that follows these "comprehensive tests" often comes with a few values highlighted. What you may not know is that many of these flagged values have little clinical significance. Yet, they can trigger repeat tests, scans, diagnostic labels, medicines and follow-up visits. The body may have changed little; the medical identity may have changed completely.

India is in the middle of a diagnostic boom. Laboratory chains, imaging centres, hospital packages and digital aggregators have made testing cheaper and more convenient. India certainly needs greater diagnostic capacity. But an important distinction is being blurred: expanding access to testing is not the same as expanding testing itself.

The history of India's ultra-processed food market offers a useful parallel. Four decades ago, large food companies did not merely create capacity; they created new consumption habits and new markets. Advertising, discounts and convenience converted occasional eating into routine consumption. The same grammar is now visible in diagnostics: "100 tests for ₹999," annual health packages, app notifications and home collections marketed to people who feel perfectly well.

When laboratory and diagnostic capacity expands rapidly in crowded urban markets, companies must keep machines and collection networks busy. Generating demand becomes commercially rational. Yet, diagnostics differ fundamentally from ordinary consumer goods. Every additional test creates another opportunity to discover an "abnormality," generating not only revenue but also anxiety and treatment.

Reference ranges are statistical constructs, not biological borders separating health from disease. Test enough parameters in a healthy person and some will inevitably fall outside. Add biological variation, imperfect specificity and differences between laboratories, and red flags become even more likely. This can then lead to more tests, specialist visits and medication.

If this continues for long enough, India could reach an absurd destination: almost every adult would carry a risk label, precondition, incidental finding or abnormal marker. The category of healthy people would shrink, even without any comparable deterioration in population health.

The policy challenge, therefore, is not whether the diagnostic sector should grow, but where and how it should grow.

India has a distribution problem as much as a capacity problem. Metropolitan markets are crowded with laboratories while many Tier-2 and Tier-3 towns still lack dependable pathology services, CT scan, MRI, histopathology and specialist diagnostics. Tax incentives, concessional credit, viability-gap support and public-private partnerships should favour facilities in underserved districts.

Quality should also become a stronger market signal. The National Accreditation Board for Testing and Calibration Laboratories' accreditation and standards related to quality, calibration, sample transport and reporting should be visible to consumers. A digital platform selling a test should identify the laboratory processing the sample and disclose its accreditation status.

Medical tests are attractively packaged even if not needed to change habits just like with eating fast food

Diagnostic aggregators require particular scrutiny because their greatest strength can also become their weakness. They lower prices, simplify booking and expand access to home collection. But a platform whose revenue rises with the number of tests sold has a structural incentive to maximize volume. Regulations should distinguish evidence-based screening from promotional packages, require disclosure of commissions and prevent mildly abnormal results from becoming automatic opportunities to upsell tests.

Advertising rules also need to catch up. "Preventive" should not become a marketing synonym for "more." Claims that larger packages provide better health protection should require evidence. High-volume packages aimed at asymptomatic consumers should explain that testing can generate false positives and unnecessary follow-up.

Doctors, hospitals, insurers and employers are part of the same ecosystem. Testing protocols should begin with a clinical question: what are we looking for, and would the result change treatment? Hospitals can audit routinely overused investigations, while employer-sponsored health checks should be judged by scientific evidence rather than by the sheer number of tests offered.

The economics of diagnostics need not be suppressed; it needs to be redirected. India needs a larger diagnostic sector, particularly in places where testing is scarce. Growth should come from widening geographic access, improving quality, shortening turnaround times and diagnosing important diseases early—not from persuading well-served urban Indians to test more often.

The lesson from ultra-processed food is not that commercial growth is inherently harmful. It is that markets can reshape behaviour long before public policy notices the consequences. A snack can change what people eat. A diagnostic test can change how people understand themselves. India needs more diagnostics where they are scarce, and greater restraint where testing is abundant but clinical purpose is not.

Why you don't need to buy a new flagship phone right now

ALL PHOTOS ISTOCKPHOTO

The modern smartphone is an advanced and mature device. Here is why you should hold on to your current phone for longer

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Every year, smartphone launches follow a familiar script. A company unveils a new flagship device with a more advanced camera system, a faster processor, some new AI capabilities, and a design tweak significant enough to distinguish it from its predecessor. And thousands of people convince themselves that their perfectly functional phone has somehow become obsolete.

Increasingly, that decision comes with a much higher price tag than it once did.

Premium smartphones that cost ₹60,000 or ₹70,000 not so long ago now routinely cross the ₹1 lakh mark. Flagship variants can cost substantially more. Foldables, even more. Smartphone brands argue that the increase in price reflects better hardware, more advanced imaging systems, and longer software support cycles. All of that is true. But it also raises the question: are consumers getting proportionately more value from each successive upgrade?

There is a paradox at the centre of this premiumisation boom. Smartphones are getting more expensive at precisely the moment when the difference between consecutive generations is often difficult to notice outside benchmarks, controlled camera comparisons, and manufacturer presentations.

THE FLAGSHIP TRAP

The smartphone industry's main problem is that phones have become too good. Even devices launched three or four years ago are extraordinarily mature products that remain good enough for everyday use: messaging, social media, photography, navigation, productivity, streaming, and gaming.

Of course, battery degradation remains a concern, and cameras continue to improve every year. Plus, AI features are evolving rapidly. But the dramatic leaps that characterized the smartphone industry in the 2010s are mostly gone. Compare a 2026 flagship against a 2025 flagship, and often even a 2024 one, and the differences aren't transformative.

While brands market each generation as revolutionary because new phones need to be sold, consumers should evaluate them more ruthlessly.

It's not hard. The first question before any purchase should not be "What's new?" It should be: "What exactly is wrong with my current phone?" If you have to dig deep to find any problem, you probably don't need a new device.

> Paradoxically, smartphones are getting more expensive just when year-on-year innovation seems to have plateaued

KEEP YOUR PHONE LONGER

The most effective way to save money on smartphones is also the least exciting—use your current phone for another year.

The replacement cycle has already been stretching globally, and smartphone brands are in it as well. While five-year software support was once considered exceptional, today, several smartphone manufacturers offer six or seven years of software updates on premium devices. Basically, your phone stays "fresh" longer.

Here's the economics of ownership in simple language: A consumer upgrading every two years instead of every four, effectively doubles the annual cost of device ownership for benefits that may be difficult to notice in everyday use. A ₹1 lakh flagship used for four years costs ₹25,000 per year. Replacing it every two years raises that effective annual cost to ₹50,000.

These savings can be substantial if you think in terms of upfront cost rather than annual cost of ownership. Few people think about smartphones this way. They should, I reckon. Our existing phones are much better than we often give them credit for.

YOU DON'T NEED THE "PRO"

If a replacement is necessary, buyers should resist another trap that manufacturers have become adept at setting—purchasing the most expensive version available.

A customer enters the market intending to spend ₹70,000. Then comes the argument for slightly more storage. Then the larger display. Or even a special edition colour. Then the premium camera system. Eventually, you get nudged towards a ₹90,000 model.

In many cases, the additional expenditure delivers remarkably little real-world value. Storage is perhaps the best example. Smartphone manufacturers increasingly offer 512GB and 1TB variants at substantial premiums. For some users, particularly mobile videographers or creators, this make sense. For most buyers, cloud storage, streaming services, and better file management mean they never come close to exhausting even half the available space.

This disconnect is the defining features of the smartphone market. Consumers often buy aspirational capabilities rather than the ones they actually need.

A better strategy is to work backwards from use cases. The "best phone" does not exist in any meaningful sense. The right phone is the one that most closely matches actual usage patterns.

LAST YEAR'S FLAGSHIP

Depreciation hits premium smartphones surprisingly quickly. That's why the one smartphone-buying rule that consistently works is this: Last year's flagship is one of the most compelling purchases in the market.

When a new flagship smartphone launches, the previous generation often sees substantial discounts through retail channels, exchange programmes, and festive offers. But the hardware does not suddenly become worse.

Last year's flagship camera remains a flagship camera. Last year's premium display remains a premium display. And, last year's processor remains vastly more powerful than most applications require. The economic logic is difficult to ignore. The steepest depreciation usually occurs during the first year, while the decline in practical usefulness is far smaller. If you're willing to sacrifice the latest model badge, you'll receive a disproportionately better value proposition.

THE MID-RANGE RENAISSANCE

Perhaps the strongest evidence that consumers should rethink smartphone purchases, however, lies in the evolution of the mid-range market.

There was a time when recommending a cheaper smartphone involved accepting obvious compromises. Displays were worse, cameras struggled in challenging conditions, performance degraded quickly, build quality was inconsistent. Those distinctions still exist, but the gaps have narrowed considerably.

Flagship smartphones do feature the most advanced hardware available, mind you. Professionals who rely heavily on cameras, creators producing mobile-first content, enthusiasts who care deeply about cutting-edge technology, and consumers with large discretionary budgets may find genuine value in premium devices. The problem is that the market increasingly encourages every buyer to behave as though they belong in that category.

The difference between a ₹30,000 phone and a ₹1.3 lakh phone remains real, of course. But the difference between the experiences they deliver is often less significant than the difference between their prices. For most consumers, an upper mid-range phone may deliver 80-90% of the flagship experience.

THE SMARTER UPGRADE

For smartphone buyers, the question to ask is: "Which phone is enough for the way I actually use it?" For many people, the answer will not be the newest flagship. It may be the device they already possess, or it may be last year's premium model bought at a discount. It could even be a well-chosen mid-range smartphone with strong software support and good cameras.

The smartphone market wants consumers to believe every year is a year of reinvention. The reality is less dramatic.

Abhishek Baxi is a New Delhi-based tech writer.

REVIEW I SONOS PLAY

A capable new speaker that can do it all, just about

The new Sonos Play speaker has great sound and is a rugged companion

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Just before I began writing this review, I was sat in my TV room with my setup of the Sonos Arc Ultra soundbar and two Sonos Play speakers, watching *Tenzing*, Jennifer Peedom's moving and breathtaking new movie on Apple TV. It was the whooshing sounds of the wind and snow blowing that had me sit upright in my seat. At times, it felt like a NatGeo production.

It was the Sonos trio that really elevated the experience. The Play speaker comes with a two-fold advantage. It can slot in seamlessly to your existing home network and connect with other Sonos speakers, and it's also rugged enough to be a great outdoor speaker. The cheaper Roam 2 costs ₹17,999, while the Play comes in at ₹35,999.

WHAT I LIKED

The Play is a bookshelf speaker that punches above its weight. It's a typical oval-shaped speaker with the top and bottom rubberized to absorb the impact. It comes with an IP67 water resistance rating. It's got a hook at the top, so you can easily hang this anywhere. It comes in at 7.57-inch tall and 1.3kg in weight. It isn't exactly light, but it is very much portable.

Where the Play shines is with the integration into the Sonos ecosystem. It connects via Wi-Fi and thanks to all the app updates, is now a seamless connection. It supports multi-room audio and almost all music services. Two Plays linked make it a stereo pair.

> The Play, when paired into a stereo system, uses Wi-Fi to connect seamlessly

What matters the most is how it sounds. It's got one woofer and two tweeters that combine for a wide soundstage. It's got solid mids, clear treble and even some bass. Vocals shine, but the speakers lack a little bit of oomph. And in jazz songs, at times, you just can't make out the finer tunes. Thankfully, with the bass not booming, and the recessed treble, your ears won't hate you if you crank up the volume. The Play will easily fill most medium-size rooms, but just don't set the volume to anything over 80% because then it gets distorted.

When paired as rear speakers and connected with the soundbar, the Play shines bright. Just pick it up, take it to another room, and you can play music on it independently. It's seamless, and it always recognizes where it has been positioned, a feature I truly loved.

TWO DOWNSIDES

The first, and most obvious downside is that you need two Play speakers for it to truly work as rear speakers in your TV room. One rear speaker, connected to the soundbar, will not do the trick. The other is the price. For it to truly work as rear speakers and create a truly surround sound experience, you'll need three devices from Sonos. The Sonos Arc Ultra (or their other soundbar) and two Play speakers at the minimum. That pushes the price up to almost ₹1,70,000. Add in the subwoofer and the price is well over ₹2,00,000.

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REVIEW I APPLE IPHONE DUO

A revolutionary new foldable phone or an aspirational collectible?

The iPhone Duo marks Apple's foray into foldable phones. How good is it, and is it worth the hefty price tag?

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The Apple iPhone Duo marks many firsts for Apple: the company's long-delayed entry into foldables, its first new iPhone in two decades, and first new hardware design since the Vision Pro headset three years ago. For new Apple chief John Ternus the Duo is vital as it's the first bit of hardware launched in his watch. The Duo is also the first mainstream smartphone that can cost up to ₹5 lakh in India. It's fair to say that there's much riding on the phone's hinged shoulders.

BEST DISPLAYS IN THE BUSINESS

With the Duo, Apple has tried to get two things right—ergonomics and versatility. The iPhone Duo takes a shape that more closely resembles a wallet or a passport, things that can be held and used with one hand. In reality, Duo's one-handed use is limited due to its weight.

When unfolded, the Duo looks very similar to the 8.5 inch iPad Mini. The Duo offers a 7.6-inch display that looks impressive in every way. Apple has not only used an OLED panel with 120 hertz (Hz) fast motion capabilities, but has also applied a nano texture on top. This means that once unfolded, there are no reflections. Apple first showcased this nano texture in its M5 MacBook Pro laptops, and the iPhone Duo is the first phone to get it.

NEW HABITS TAKE TIME

Display aside, has the software experience evolved to keep pace? Apple is aware of this question, which is is why, on launch day on 23 October, the company shared a list of 54 apps that have conformed to make the most of Apple's new design layouts on the foldable smartphone.

Beyond these chosen apps though, the experience is currently hit-or-miss. Most Google apps are yet to customize their app functionalities to the new screen layout, including Gmail, Google Docs and YouTube—three of the most-used everyday apps on phones today. The same is also true for most games right now, which haven't yet made the jump to the big screen's unusual 4.3:3 aspect ratio.

Apps that have adopted the custom design needs of the iPhone Duo feel distinctly unique, while those that haven't—including a major app like Spotify—feel like stretched versions of the regular iPhone apps. The result can feel jarring.

What can be more of a switch for loyal Apple users, will be the shift to new habits that the iPhone Duo necessitates.

For starters, there's no Face ID, which now makes way for Touch ID integrated into the slim fingerprint sensor on the right edge. On any other iPhone, simply lifting it can unlock the device and open to the last-used screen.

Users will also have to adjust to the screen dimensions. The external display, though as crisp and sharp as on any flagship iPhone, is only 5.4-inch in size. Moreover, the display comes with an aspect ratio of about 13:9, as against the normal video aspect ratio standard of 16:9. This means that the outer display is more of a square than the rectangular dimensions that people are used to. As a result, most apps that do not adapt to this layout naturally, creating inconsistencies such as cropped buttons. Case in point: in an app as popular as Google Pay, the 'submit' button of entering the security PIN for a transaction is almost cropped out of the external display. There are many more such instances as of right now.

There's no denying that apps that work well do look quite wonderful, and when it works, Apple's purpose-built screen animations and a smooth flow-over between the two displays is something that competitors simply do not offer right now.

CAMERAS AND PERFORMANCE

The other big question about the iPhone Duo is if all this versatility of the two screens makes life tangibly better for any subset of users. Thinking of 'pro' or power users, the proposition is difficult to determine.

Most creators would still want the iPhone 18 Pro (or Pro Max) simply because of how much better the Pro cameras are. Though the iPhone Duo has a 48-megapixel ultrawide camera that was sorely missed in the single-camera iPhone Air of 2025, many 'pro' features remain missing. Of course, this argument may prove to be futile, for the iPhone Duo is imagined more for a top executive juggling spreadsheets and Zoom calls—and not necessarily taking photos all the way.

That, though, does not mean the iPhone Duo lacks firepower. It is powered by Apple's custom A20 Pro chip, which is among the best, if not the very best, in smartphones today. Its chops are seen in serious video editing: The larger display, coupled with the A20 Pro, makes light work of 2-minute edit of a 4K video for social media.

Then there's the battery, which should last a full day for most users. With the heavy workload of journalists too, the iPhone Duo lasts easily until late evening on a full charge—with an Apple Watch and a pair of AirPods paired and used extensively.

THE RIGHT AUDIENCE

There's no denying that the iPhone Duo has a certain charm that most smartphones have not offered in a long, long time. It feels like a new device to learn about, with a hinge that can stop at practically any angle. There's also the social charisma that the iPhone Duo—it is a deeply aspirational device.

And therein lies the customer base for the Duo—people who don't mind the obvious splurge, and are thrilled to be among the first to own Apple's foray into foldable phones. Five years from today, the first Duo could very well become a rare collectible.